

The House of Bernarda Alba



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF FEDERICO GARCÍA LORCA

Federico García Lorca was born to a wealthy landowning family in Andalusia (southern Spain). Raised between the city of Granada and the small towns of Fuente Vaqueros and Valderrubio/Asquerosa (where this play is set), Lorca took an interest in the piano and music composition as an adolescent. One of his university professors convinced him to study law and philosophy in Madrid, where he began writing and befriended a generation of prominent artists, including luminaries like the filmmaker Luis Buñuel and the painter Salvador Dalí. In fact, García Lorca was reportedly in love with Dalí; homosexuality and unfulfillable desire were constant themes in his work. The 1928 poetry collection *Gypsy Ballads* won García Lorca international recognition for his depiction of rural Andalusian life. He spent the following year at Columbia University in New York, which shaped his thinking about capitalism and modern life. He returned to Spain to write plays and direct a theater company called La Barraca, which traveled around the Spanish countryside, performing classic plays. But in July 1936, fascists in the Spanish military launched a coup against the democratically-elected government and took control of several of the country's cities, including Granada, where García Lorca lived. The following month, at just 38 years old, he was arrested and executed as part of the nationalists' social cleansing campaign. He is often seen as a martyr in Spain today, and his body still has never been found.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

The House of Bernarda Alba was written in the days leading up to the breakout of the Spanish Civil War, as deep tensions rooted in the country's longstanding political and social divisions exploded into armed conflict. In the years after World War I, Spain was still largely agricultural, with the Catholic church and a powerful landowning class dominating the poor, rural majority. Attempts to restrain the king's power and democratize the country had long been popular but unsuccessful, until King Alfonso XIII agreed to call elections in 1931. Left-wing parties won, established the government known as the Second Spanish Republic, and instituted many pro-worker and anti-clerical policies. Right-wing opposition to the new government grew, supported by Nazi Germany, Fascist Italy, and the Catholic church. Conservatives governed from 1933 to 1936, when left-wing parties again won the election, and the streets began erupting into violence. Conservatives in the military united to launch a coup against the government in July. They managed to take some cities, including Seville and

Granada, García Lorca's hometown, where they promptly murdered him. But most of the country remained under the government's control. It would take three years of fighting, from 1936 to 1939, for the conservative nationalists to conquer the whole country and establish a fascist military dictatorship under the rule of General Francisco Franco. Not only did the nationalists kill hundreds of thousands of artists, dissidents, and other "enemies of the state" during and after the war—including García Lorca—but from 1939 to 1975, the Franco dictatorship also heavily censored artistic expression of all kinds and forcibly imposed the same conservative, patriarchal Catholic values that García Lorca critiques in this play on the whole Spanish population. The remarkable coincidence that *The House of Bernarda Alba* was perhaps the last major Spanish literary work published before the war, combined with the famous circumstances surrounding García Lorca's death, help explain the play's enduring popularity today.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

García Lorca is best known today for this play, along with [Blood Wedding](#) and *Yerma*. These three works are often collectively labeled the "Rural Trilogy" due to their similar themes and settings. García Lorca's other principal works are poetry collections: *Gypsy Ballads*, which first launched him to international fame; *Poet in New York*, which focused on his time at Columbia University in 1929 and 1930; and the *Sonnets of Dark Love*, which he wrote for the last man he loved before his death. García Lorca's major contemporaries and influences in the Generation of '27 include Rafael Alberti, who also explored Spanish folkloric traditions through works like *Marinero en tierra*; Jorge Guillén, who experimented with the limits of language in his multivolume collection *Cántico*; and the surrealist-influenced Vicente Aleixandre, who won the 1977 Nobel Prize in Literature for works like *La destrucción o el amor* and *Historia del corazón*. *The House of Bernarda Alba* is still frequently performed today and has been extensively adapted for the stage and screen all around the world. Some of the most notable adaptations include the ballet *Las Desenamoras*, the German opera *Bernarda Albas Haus*, and the off-Broadway musical *Bernarda Alba*.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** La casa de Bernarda Alba (The House of Bernarda Alba)
- **When Written:** 1936
- **Where Written:** Granada, Spain
- **When Published:** March 8, 1945 (First performance at

Teatro Avenida in Buenos Aires)

- **Literary Period:** Modernism
- **Genre:** Drama, Tragedy
- **Setting:** Bernarda Alba's house (in Valderrubio, Granada province, Andalusia, Spain)
- **Climax:** Bernarda shoots at Pepe el Romano and Adela hangs herself.
- **Antagonist:** Bernarda Alba, Pepe el Romano, Patriarchy, and Tradition

EXTRA CREDIT

Unfinished Masterpiece. Since García Lorca was murdered shortly after writing *The House of Bernarda Alba*, the play was neither published nor performed during his lifetime. In fact, the version available to us today was his rough draft, which he considered an incomplete and immature work of theater.

Based on True Story. García Lorca based *The House of Bernarda Alba* on his neighbors in the Andalusian village of Valderrubio, where his family owned property and he spent much of his childhood. Today, it is possible to visit Bernarda Alba's real house, which has been turned into a museum dedicated to the play.



PLOT SUMMARY

Set in a small, traditional Andalusian village just before the outbreak of the Spanish Civil War, *The House of Bernarda Alba* follows the well-to-do Bernarda Alba and her five unmarried daughters—Angustias (age 39), Magdalena (age 30), Amelia (age 27), Martirio (age 24), and Adela (age 20)—in the days just after her husband Antonio's death. Trapped inside Bernarda's **white-walled** house by a combination of their mother's tyranny, their society's restrictive gender roles, and their lack of anywhere else to go, the five daughters struggle to imagine futures for themselves and start to fight over the one eligible bachelor left in town, the womanizing Pepe el Romano.

Just after Antonio's funeral, Poncia and The Maid, who work as servants in Bernarda's house, clean frantically and commiserate about how cruelly Bernarda treats them. After all, Bernarda spends her life locked inside, gossiping about the neighbors and worrying that her daughters will marry someone of lower social status. Upon returning from the funeral, Bernarda immediately starts criticizing the Maid, Poncia, and her daughters for infractions ranging from mourning too loudly to offering her the wrong color fan. She explains that she intends to make her daughters spend eight years grieving inside the house, as tradition dictates. Meanwhile, from deeper inside the house, Bernarda's mother Maria Josefa screams about how her daughter ignores her and how she wishes to be free.

When Adela reports that Angustias was eavesdropping on the local men's conversation after the funeral, Bernarda starts beating Angustias and demanding an explanation. Bernarda tells Poncia that nobody in town is good enough for her daughters, but she would never allow them to move away, either. The daughters discuss their bleak views on love and marriage, and a fight breaks out between the daughters and Bernarda when it comes out that Pepe wants to marry Angustias for her money (as the daughter of Bernarda's first husband, Angustias is wealthier than her sisters). Elderly Maria Josefa comes onstage, says she wants to leave the village and get married, and insists that none of her granddaughters will ever find a husband. The sisters violently drag Maria Josefa back to her room and lock the door.

Sometime later, the four older sisters are **embroidering** linen in preparation for their wedding days. Angustias explains that Pepe el Romano has asked her to marry him. Poncia congratulates her, but also warns that all men eventually grow tired of their wives and turn to drinking and adultery instead. In private, Poncia also tells Adela that she saw Adela watching Pepe and Angustias meet at night—and she knows that Adela is secretly in love with Pepe, too.

The women hear the young fieldhands coming back from work and dream of going outside, but they know they can't. "To be born a woman is the worst punishment," Amelia concludes. Angustias reveals that the photo of Pepe she kept under her pillow has disappeared, and Poncia finds it in Martirio's bed. Martirio claims this was a joke, but Adela accuses Martirio of *also* loving Pepe, and the other sisters tell Angustias that Pepe just wants her money. Poncia privately warns Bernarda of the "monstrous" conflict brewing among her daughters, because it's clear that Pepe and Adela are really in love. But Bernarda insists that everything is fine and tells Poncia to "work and keep your mouth shut." When Poncia points out that Pepe was talking to Adela late at night, Bernarda calls her a liar, but Martirio realizes there is a problem. Meanwhile, the townspeople drag a woman into the streets, intending to kill her, because she had a child out of wedlock and then killed it. Bernarda cheers them on as Adela holds her stomach in horror, which suggests that she is pregnant with Pepe's child.

A neighbor, Prudencia, visits for dinner and explains how conflicts over her husband's inheritance and her daughter's disobedience are tearing her family apart. Bernarda praises her for preserving her family's honor and taking solace in the church, even if it makes her day-to-day life miserable. Bernarda shares the news of Angustias's engagement, and Prudencia congratulates the family, even though the pearl engagement ring reminds her of tears. Prudencia leaves, Bernarda assures Angustias that Pepe isn't hiding anything from her, and the other sisters gaze up at the stars and dream of freedom. Bernarda chastises Poncia for suggesting that something is wrong with Angustias's engagement, but Poncia and the Maid

agree that Bernarda is choosing to live in denial. Poncia thinks Adela will do anything to win Pepe back from Angustias.

Maria Josefa walks onstage with a baby ewe, sings a song about going to the seashore and having children, and begs Martirio to let her out of the house. Martirio locks her back inside her room instead. Martirio then runs into Adela, whose hair is disheveled. They get into a fight and conclude that they don't see each other as sisters anymore. Adela announces that she will do anything to get Pepe, even if it means ruining her family's reputation or killing one of her sisters. In fact, she has just come back from having sex with Pepe by the river. Bernarda arrives and confronts Adela, who says she only cares about Pepe. She reveals that Pepe is waiting behind the house, in the corral, and she tells Angustias to go see him. Instead, Bernarda gets her gun, runs into the corral with Martirio, and fires. Even though she missed Pepe (he rode away on his [horse](#)), she tells Adela that Pepe is dead. Adela goes into her room and hangs herself; when Poncia discovers her body, Bernarda announces that "my daughter has died a virgin" because she still hasn't realized the truth about Pepe and Adela. Bernarda insists that it's time to mourn and demands silence from the whole family.



CHARACTERS

Bernarda Alba – The play's central character is the 60-year-old mother of Angustias, Magdalena, Amelia, Martirio, and Adela. She is the matriarch of the house where the action takes place. Preoccupied with tradition, status, and the dictates of the Catholic Church, Bernarda stubbornly imposes her beliefs on her daughters and only grows more tyrannical the more they resist. To maintain her reputation in her village, she spends much of her time spying on the neighbors and treats lower-class characters with arrogance and disdain—including Poncia and the Maid, who have worked in her house for decades. Her five daughters remain single (and desperate to leave Bernarda's house) because she has rejected all of her daughters' past suitors on the grounds of class. In this way, her fixation on the honor code enables her to dominate and control her family. During the play, she imposes eight years of mourning inside the house on her daughters after her husband, Antonio's, death—although she seems to care more about playing the part of a mourning widow than actually grieving his death. Later, she finally accepts Pepe el Romano's proposal to Angustias, but refuses to see all the clear warning signs that he is simply using her for her money and loves Adela instead. When Adela finally confronts Bernarda, she attacks Pepe, which indirectly leads to Adela's suicide. Bernarda never admits the error in her ways. Bernarda's character serves as a stand-in for Spanish womanhood in general: she demonstrates how women internalize and pass on patriarchal honor codes that confine them to the home and prevent them from living free, complete

lives.

Angustias – Thirty-nine-year-old Angustias is Bernarda's oldest daughter and the only one whose father is Bernarda's first husband (and not her second, Antonio, who dies just before the play begins). Angustias inherits all of her father's property as well as much of her stepfather's, so she is by far the richest of her siblings. But she is also the ugliest, sickliest, and bitterest, particularly since she is too old for marriage by the standards of her culture. Still, Pepe el Romano proposes to her—no doubt for the sake of her wealth—and she jumps at the chance to finally leave Bernarda's house. (Of course, given how the play ends, she ultimately won't be able to.) Her name, which roughly translates to "anguish," captures her unhappy predicament. Her anguish is the product of the patriarchal honor codes that define her value through a prospective husband's eyes—in terms of her appearance, age, and wealth.

Magdalena – Thirty-year-old Magdalena is Bernarda's second daughter and the eldest of her children with Don Antonio. Caring and perceptive, she is the only person to truly mourn her father's passing, and she tries to look out for Angustias and Adela by warning them about Pepe el Romano's double-crossing and unseemly motives. While Bernarda desperately wants Magdalena to marry, she says "to hell with being a woman!" and resolves to live independently, to whatever extent she can in rural Spain in the 1930s. Arguably, she is the play's kindest and most ethical character—but also the most cynical, as she clearly understands the limits that patriarchy places on women and harbors no illusions about love or marriage saving her from them.

Amelia – Twenty-seven-year-old Amelia is Bernarda's middle daughter. Compared to her sisters, she is agreeable, conventional, and relatively uninterested in men and marriage. As a result, she does not play a significant part in the play's main conflicts. However, she also fears her mother and often misses the subtext to the other characters' conversations. Indeed, much like her mother, she thinks only about fulfilling what society asks of her, and she simply does not acknowledge or pursue her own desires. The play captures this character trait through metaphor by having Amelia say she prefers to shut her eyes rather than look at the stars. In this sense, Amelia represents how people like Bernarda pass down their repressive value systems from generation to generation.

Martirio – Twenty-four-year-old Martirio is Bernarda's fourth daughter. She deeply resents her mother and sisters because she once had a suitor, Enrique Humanas, whom Bernarda secretly turned away because his father was a common fieldhand. (In an ironic twist of fate, Enrique went on to marry a wealthier girl.) When Martirio notices Pepe el Romano visiting the house, she develops feelings for him, too, and even steals Angustias's picture of him. But she quickly learns that he has no interest in her. She understands that Pepe's prospective marriage to Angustias is essentially transactional, but she

grows to hate her younger sister Adela, unable to bear the thought that Pepe actually loves her instead. She follows and confronts Adela at the end of the play, which indirectly leads to Adela's suicide. Martirio's bitterness and destructive impulses reflect the dark consequences of the family's confinement and Spain's honor codes for women.

Adela – Twenty-year-old Adela is Bernarda's youngest, most beautiful, and least cynical daughter. She falls in love with Pepe el Romano, who makes plans to marry her older sister Angustias but seduces and sleeps with Adela in secret. Adela is determined not to let her mother's dictates crush her sense of passion and independence. She refuses to be spurned (like Martirio) or resign herself to spinsterhood (like Magdalena). But her stubborn insistence on living according to her own rules also contributes to her tragic death at the end of the play. When Martirio points out the straw on Adela's dress, which serves as incontrovertible evidence of her affair with Pepe, Bernarda goes to shoot Pepe and pretends that she was successful. Adela responds by committing suicide. Depending on the interpretation, Adela's tragic, final act of resistance may reflect her desperate love for Pepe, her refusal to submit to her mother, or her recognition that women can never truly be free under traditional rural Spanish conceptions of honor.

Maria Josefa – Maria Josefa is Bernarda's senile 80-year-old mother who lives in an interior room of the house and deliriously tries to escape several times in the play. She accuses Bernarda of locking her away and neglecting her, and she repeatedly announces that she wants to move to the coast and get married. The whole family works together to lock her back in her room at the end of Act 1, and in the middle of Act 3, she escapes onto the stage holding a lamb, which she claims as her child. Maria Josefa's character represents women's repressed desire for freedom. Her dream of leaving Bernarda's house by marrying (which she shares with Bernarda's daughters) demonstrates how rural Spain's traditional honor code continues to oppress women from generation to generation.

The Maid – The Maid is the lower-ranking servant in Bernarda's house. Her duties consist primarily of cooking and cleaning, announcing visitors, and looking after Maria Josefa. Except in the first scene, where she reveals her past relationship with Don Antonio and her dialogue with Poncia introduces the audience to Bernarda's tyrannical personality, her role is primarily to accompany and announce major action in the play.

Poncia – Poncia is the head servant in Bernarda's house, the TK. She is the voice of conscience throughout the play, which makes her a foil to Bernarda. Although Poncia has worked for Bernarda for three decades and they are both 60 years old, Bernarda still treats Poncia with disdain because of her lower-class birth. As a result, Bernarda ignores her many warnings about the trouble brewing between Adela, Angustias, and Martirio. In turn, Poncia resents Bernarda and dreams of

finally scolding her to her face. While Poncia is generally warmer and more perceptive than Bernarda—especially when it comes to the five daughters—she also rigidly enforces the same honor codes for women's behavior. For instance, she repeatedly tells Bernarda's daughters to expect little from their future husbands, citing her own experience. Crucially, she is the one who discovers Adela's body at the end of the play.

Pepe el Romano – Pepe el Romano is Angustias, Martirio, and Adela's love interest, and seemingly the only man in their village whom Bernarda deems high-class enough for her daughters. While he never appears onstage, Pepe visits Bernarda's house each night to talk to Angustias and Adela through their windows. Though he proposes marriage to Angustias, likely because she has inherited all of her father's wealth, he carries on an affair with Adela, which leaves her pregnant and indirectly contributes to her suicide at the end of the play. His womanizing and impropriety reflect how traditional Spanish conceptions of honor give men all but complete power over women—and therefore also license to mistreat them.

Antonio María Benavides – Antonio María Benavides is Bernarda Alba's second husband and the father of Magdalena, Amelia, Martirio, and Adela. He dies shortly before the events of the play, much of which deals with his family's conflicts over how to mourn him. While Bernarda remembers him as an honorable, ethical man, the Maid reveals that he used to "lift up [her] skirts" in the corral. Like Pepe el Romano, he is more of an idea than an actual character in the play, which further shows how men abuse their power over women. The perception of honor matters more than actually honorable behavior in the rural culture that Bernarda and her family uphold.

Prudencia – Prudencia is a neighbor who visits Bernarda Alba's house for dinner at the beginning of Act 3. She is 50 years old, a decade younger than Bernarda, but she is similarly conservative, religious, and reputation-obsessed. Her family is falling apart and she is miserable due to a fight over inheritance—which makes her a foil for Bernarda—but Bernarda thinks Prudencia is right to put her honor above her happiness.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



FREEDOM, DESIRE, AND TRAGEDY

The House of Bernarda Alba begins with the tyrannical title character, Bernarda Alba, locking her five daughters in their small village house to

mourn the passing of their father Don Antonio. Tradition dictates that they spend eight years inside, wearing only **black**—just as it states that their value as women depends on whom they marry. Fed up with their circumscribed lives and Bernarda's rigid social codes, the daughters start dreaming of escape through the only socially acceptable option: love. Three of the daughters end up entangled with the same man, Pepe el Romano. Pepe proposes marriage to Bernarda's eldest daughter, Angustias—who stands to inherit most of the family's estate—even as he carries on a secret love affair with the youngest, Adela, who decides she will do anything to be with him, up to and including destroying her family. Meanwhile, the fourth daughter, Martirio, is desperately in love with Pepe, but he rejects her. Love is thus both Bernarda's strategy for exerting control over her daughters, and the daughters' strategy for forging their own paths in life. Their competing desires trigger the play's tragic end, which depends on a twofold punch of dramatic irony: Adela hangs herself because she wrongly believes that Pepe is dead, while Bernarda announces that “my daughter has died a virgin”—still refusing to believe the clear evidence that Adela not only had sex with Pepe but is also pregnant with his child. Throughout the play, as though to underline the daughters' predicament, Bernarda's mother (Maria Josefa) and her servants (Poncia and the Maid) also dream of leaving her house and building better lives for themselves elsewhere.

The characters' futile attempts to fulfill impossible desires drives the play's action and leads to its inexorable, tragic conclusion, in which Bernarda tells her daughters and audience to “look death in the face.” When they reach the limit of their ability to achieve what they want, García Lorca's characters stubbornly choose to live in denial and keep trying anyway, as their quest for freedom is the only thing that makes their lives worth living. Obsessed with the fantasy of a pure bloodline, Bernarda keeps believing that her daughters will find the right husbands, even as she locks them inside for years on end and refuses to either let them leave the village or marry a neighbor of a lower social class. (There is simply nobody left for them to marry.) Angustias refuses to believe that Pepe is marrying her for money, Adela refuses to believe that Pepe will ultimately choose money over love, and Martirio refuses to believe that Pepe loves Adela instead. All of them are wrong, all of them refuse to admit it, and thus all of them are responsible for Adela's death at the end of the play. In this way, as throughout his work, García Lorca suggests that all humans are caught in a tragic paradox: the value in human life comes from pursuing freedom and desire beyond society's constraints, and yet it's perhaps impossible to fully achieve the freedom people seek or the fantasies they desire. But the play suggests that people must *believe* that they can in order to keep the pursuit of freedom and desire alive, and this false belief often leads people to ruin.



PATRIARCHY AND DOMINATION

Twenty-first-century audiences might consider *The House of Bernarda Alba* a feminist masterpiece, but not because its characters are empowered or independent. While it's true that all of the characters who appear in this play are women, the whole work is also set within the four **white** walls (and interior patio) of Bernarda Alba's house because these women are simply not allowed to leave. In the conservative, Catholic rural Spain of the 1930s, women were expected to stay in the home, gossiping and **embroidering**, and their identity, status, and rights derived entirely from that of their fathers and husbands. Bernarda desperately wants to marry Angustias off to Pepe because she recognizes the social risks of living in an all-woman household; she trains her daughters to accept mistreatment and misbehavior from men, and she beats them when they suggest that they should be allowed to make their own decisions. She and Poncia curse women who have consensual sex before marriage or who are assaulted in the olive groves, and they agree that men will behave however they please and it is women's responsibility to resist them. Poncia even tells Bernarda's daughters that it's men's nature to drink, cheat, and ignore their wives, and the most women can do is fight back just enough to win their husbands' attention. The daughters adapt to these edicts in varying ways. Whereas Magdalena says, “to hell with being a woman!” and refuses to marry, for instance, Amelia recognizes that “to be born a woman is the worst punishment” but accepts that she will have to marry a man she does not love. And when Adela declares that “my body will be for anyone I please” (and acts accordingly), she is protesting not male domination itself, but merely the marriage codes that mean she cannot choose *which* man will dominate her.

The play's subtitle, *A Drama of Women in the Villages of Spain*, makes it clear that García Lorca hoped to capture women's predicament in his country more broadly. Bernarda's tyranny shows not only how male domination harms women, but also how it leads some of them to internalize patriarchal beliefs and impose them on other women. And the male impropriety that García Lorca references throughout the play suggests that patriarchy enables men to act in more violent, irresponsible, and cruel ways than they would otherwise.



CLASS AND HONOR

Bernarda Alba's obsession with purity, reputation, and the family bloodline stems from her family's traditional place in the Spanish class hierarchy. Much like García Lorca's family, Bernarda's family belongs to the lower nobility and was once powerful and respected in their small, traditional Andalusian village; Bernarda clings desperately to this identity, but she recognizes that passing it down to her daughters depends on marrying them to men of a similar class. This is why she refuses to let Martirio marry the

fieldhand's son Enrique Humanas, and why she jumps at the opportunity to marry Angustias to Pepe el Romano, even though he is clearly just interested in her money. Bernarda's investment in social hierarchy is also clear from her classist attitudes: she tells working-class Poncia that "the poor are like animals" and taunts her because her mother ran a brothel; when Poncia tries to share her sincere concerns about the five sisters' marriage prospects, Bernarda dismisses her because "you are my servant, and I pay you." Most of all, Bernarda is obsessed with appearances, rumors, and reputation because she knows that any blemishes could permanently diminish her family's status in the community's eyes. Yet her emphasis on class backfires: she ignores Poncia's warnings to her own peril, loses others' respect by mistreating them in the name of honor codes, and keeps her daughters single because she can't find anyone high-class enough for them. Through Bernarda's self-defeating obsession with class, García Lorca shows that, in unequal societies where status depends on honor and descent, people sacrifice their freedom and happiness for the sake of appearances.



TRADITION AND MODERNITY IN SPAIN

Federico García Lorca wrote *The House of Bernarda Alba* in the weeks immediately preceding the outbreak of the Spanish Civil War—and his own

death at the hands of a fascist firing squad. But to intellectuals like him, the war was not altogether unexpected; rather, it emerged from the exact decades-old social and political tensions that he explored throughout his work. This play is no exception. Bernarda Alba's conflict with her daughters is in large part a metaphor for the growing conflict between traditional and modern ways of life in early 20th-century Spain. Given her obsession with class, reputation, women's honor, and above all the church, Bernarda clearly represents her society's longstanding social mores and hierarchies. In contrast, her daughters begin questioning and even outright rejecting repressive traditions as part of their quest for freedom and independence. For instance, contrary to her name ("martyrdom"), Martirio declares that "God must have abandoned me" during her argument with Adela; shortly thereafter, Adela breaks her mother's cane, which she calls a "tyrant's rod." Bernarda responds by escalating the conflict: she gets her gun and shoots at Pepe el Romano, which leads indirectly to Adela's suicide. This escalating family conflict reflects the escalating generational and geographical conflict that led to Spain's civil war: while tradition still ruled in places like Bernarda's village, it was fast dissolving in the cities, particularly under the left-wing, pro-worker government that redistributed land and limited the church's power in the years immediately leading up to the war. While seldom overtly political, García Lorca was undoubtedly a man of the left, and it's little coincidence that critics have long read the novel's

tragic conclusion and haunting final line—Bernarda telling her daughters they must mourn Adela's death and screaming "Silence!"—as an unwitting metaphor for the coming Franco dictatorship's reign of terror over the Spanish population (and artists in particular).



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



WHITE, BLACK, AND COLOR

The House of Bernarda Alba is suffused with the contrast between white and black, which

represents the binary of virgin and widow that defines women's social value in Bernarda's village. The play is also occasionally punctuated with flashes of color that reflect the possibility of living outside of this binary.

The play's opening stage directions highlight the *blanquísima* (very white) walls of Bernarda's house, which soon become associated with Poncia and the Maid's vigorous cleaning, as well as the white **embroidered** linens that represent Bernarda's daughters' virginity at the time of their marriages (if those marriages ever happen). These images of purity contrast with the black mourning clothes that Bernarda and her daughters wear throughout the play in Antonio's memory. White and black seem to be the only two appropriate colors for Bernarda, as they reflect the only two socially appropriate roles for unmarried women: virgin and widow. But Adela defies Bernarda's demands by giving her a red and green fan and then wearing her green birthday dress. Her use of color represents her intent to defy the social roles prescribed by her mother, but it also foreshadow her decision to commit suicide rather than accept those roles at the end of the play.



EMBROIDERY

Embroidery represents not just women's traditional role in the honor code governing

Spanish village life, but also the collapse of this code as those roles start to shift in modern times. Customarily, upper-class men in a village like Bernarda's spend their lives breeding **horses** and overseeing their farm estates, while women stay inside, embroidering, having children, and keeping up with the news on family and neighbors. (Because of their class, Bernarda and her daughters don't have to cook, clean, or raise their children—they have servants for that.) Thus, while embroidering represents the pinnacle of feminine refinement according to tradition, in this play, it also comes to stand for how tradition renders them powerless and irrelevant.

Traditionally, as part of a wedding dowry, women would offer

an *ajuar*—a collection of embroidered linens and furnishings for their new home. Bernarda orders her daughters to spend their eight years of mourning embroidering, and at the beginning of Act 2, Magdalena is helping embroider sheets for her sisters' *ajuares*. But since the play makes it clear that none of them will likely ever marry—at least not if they stay in their village—it also becomes apparent that their embroidery is an act of folly. The women's embroidery is evidence of how Bernarda wants her daughters to waste their lives in pursuit of an outmoded value system.



HORSES

Horses represent traditional masculinity, male sexuality, and men's power over women in

Bernarda's village. While the association between men and horses stems from the Spanish nobleman's traditional occupation, overseeing his fields on horseback, it also gives them a mobility and authority that women lack. For instance, while Bernarda and her daughters could scarcely venture far from their home even if they wanted to, Pepe el Romano rides far on his horse to visit Angustias and Adela nightly. He even survives Bernarda's shooting by riding away into the night.

Bernarda also keeps a corral with horses and mules behind her house. Her neighbor Prudencia's highest praise for Bernarda is that her herd is well-bred, and Bernarda describes a stallion in the corral that cannot wait to mate—which is a clear metaphor for Pepe's virility and foreshadows his tryst with Adela. In fact, Martirio and Amelia comment that they hear sounds coming from the corral at night—this is clearly Pepe and Adela, but Amelia chalks it up to an unruly mule. This association between mating animals, human sexuality, and the creation of a pure bloodline exposes the sense in which the traditional honor code in Bernarda's village is really an elaborate scheme to protect men's sexual access to women.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Farrar, Straus, and Giroux edition of *Three Plays* published in 1993.

Act 1 Quotes

☞ VOICE: Bernarda!

PONCIA: (*Calling out*) She's coming! (To the MAID) Scrub everything clean. If Bernarda doesn't see things shine, she'll tear out the little hair I have left!

MAID: What a woman!

PONCIA: She tyrannizes everyone around her. She could sit on your heart and watch you die for a whole year without taking that cold smile off her damn face! Scrub! Scrub those tiles!

Related Characters: The Maid, Poncia (speaker), Bernarda Alba

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 194

Explanation and Analysis

The House of Bernarda Alba opens with Poncia and the Maid frantically cleaning Bernarda's house during her husband Antonio's funeral. As they scrub and organize, they warn the audience about Bernarda's cruelty—which she makes a habit of directing toward people from lower social classes, like them. Bernarda's arrogance, unpredictability, and penchant for violence make her a thankless boss and mother; Poncia and the Maid live bound to and terrified of her, much like her children, although they at least get to make their own decisions about marriage and family.

Opening the play with the servants' dialogue is a significant stylistic choice. For one, it marks García Lorca's skepticism about the social mores that dominate Bernarda and her family's lives: while they have no interest in seeing the world through Poncia and the Maid's eyes, he encourages his readers and audiences to do so. This would have been radical in 1930s Spain (even if the play would not be performed there for decades, due to the civil war and Franco dictatorship). Moreover, García Lorca shows the audience that Poncia (and, to a lesser extent, the Maid) will be their guide to the family's conflicts throughout the play. Poncia has practically raised the sisters, and they all confide in her in a way they cannot in either one another or their mother. In fact, Poncia is more of a mother figure to them than their real mother, which reflects how Bernarda's authoritarian personality—and the oppressive social norms responsible for it—make family a matter of property and status, not love and care.

☛☛ PONCIA: Thirty years, washing her sheets. Thirty years, eating her leftovers. Nights watching over her when she coughs. Entire days peering through cracks, to spy on the neighbors and bring her the gossip. A life with no secrets from each other. And yet—damn her! May she have a horrible pain—like nails stuck in her eyes!

Related Characters: Poncia (speaker), Bernarda Alba, The Maid

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 195

Explanation and Analysis

Shortly before Bernarda's arrival, Poncia describes the resentment she has felt for her boss—and stubbornly held onto—for decades. Given her steadfast dedication to the rural Spanish class system, Bernarda makes Poncia do virtually anything she doesn't want to at home and goes to great lengths to constantly remind Poncia of her inferior social status. As Poncia explains here, not only does she have to wash Bernarda's clothes and take care of her when she's sick, but she also only gets to eat whatever Bernarda and her daughters don't finish, and she even has to serve as Bernarda's eyes or ears, spying on the neighbors so that Bernarda doesn't have to (and isn't seen peeping). Yet the play will show that, because of the class system, Poncia has to pretend to be Bernarda's friend, can't point out Bernarda's misbehavior, and will absolutely never convince Bernarda to change or see her as an equal.

García Lorca thus uses Poncia and Bernarda's relationship to demonstrate how strict class systems like rural Spain's bind people together in misery: it makes them dependent on one another while convincing them that they are not and should not be equals. This system has turned Bernarda into an unspeakably cruel monster and prevented Poncia from living freely or fulfilling her potential.

☛☛ (As the two hundred women mourners finish coming in, BERNARDA ALBA and her five daughters appear. BERNARDA is leaning on a cane)

BERNARDA: (To the MAID) Silence!

Related Characters: Bernarda Alba (speaker), Adela, The Maid, Antonio María Benavides

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 199

Explanation and Analysis

Bernarda first comes onstage holding the cane that symbolizes her power over her household and screaming at the Maid to be quiet. The Maid is grieving the loss of Bernarda's husband, the late Don Antonio, but Bernarda tells her to be quiet because she considers it inappropriate for the servants to speak unless spoken to. This is ironic because, with the exception of Magdalena, Bernarda and her daughters clearly do *not* mourn him—they perform all the social rituals associated with mourning but do not actually grieve his loss. Bernarda's refusal to hear the Maid weep clearly shows how she consistently puts appearances before reality.

This passage is particularly important because Bernarda will repeat her line—"Silence!"—in the play's closing scene. In fact, this is the very last word in the play, and it is also Bernarda's response to another, more tragic death: Adela's suicide. In the wake of a family member's death, she demands not that people express their feelings or reflect on the significance of their loss, but rather that they behave in socially appropriate ways to preserve the family's reputation. In this way, she turns even mourning into an occasion to exert control over her family. Bernarda's demand for "Silence!" represents this control, as well as her refusal to speak (or hear) the truth about her family and the way the culture she lives in silences women's voices and desires.

☛☛ BERNARDA: The poor are like animals; they seem to be made of other substances.

Related Characters: Bernarda Alba (speaker), The Maid, Poncia

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 199

Explanation and Analysis

After chastising the Maid for crying, Bernarda voices her classism by comparing poor people to animals and declaring that the lower classes are "made of other substances." This is a convenient, self-serving excuse for class inequality and cruelty towards the poor. It suggests that people like Bernarda have more wealth, power, and status than people like Poncia and the Maid because there is simply something

different—and better—about them. If rich and poor people are “made of [different] substances,” then class differences are natural, inherent, and essential: they cannot change, and so Bernarda’s tyrannical rule over people like the Maid is justified. Of course, this is very different from how most people think about class in the 21st century. But in a highly stratified, traditional society like 1930s rural Spain, where class status was passed down from generation to generation and seldom changed, it was an appealing and even popular notion.

☞ ADELA: Here you are. (*She gives her a round fan decorated with red and green flowers*)

BERNARDA: (*Hurling the fan to the floor*) Is this the fan you give to a widow? Give me a black one, and learn to respect your father’s memory!

Related Characters: Bernarda Alba, Adela (speaker), Antonio María Benavides

Related Themes:    

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 204-205

Explanation and Analysis

The play is set in the scorching Andalusian summer, and to cope with the heat, Bernarda demands a fan from her daughters. In these lines, Adela graciously offers her fan to her mother, but Bernarda tersely rejects it because it is not black—and only black clothing and accessories are socially permissible during the family’s eight years of mourning. Bernarda is furious to see her daughter defy tradition, as she believes that her family’s status depends on hewing to it meticulously. But she also doesn’t seem to grasp how alien and unreasonable her rules seem to everyone else.

Bernarda’s rules against color become a recurring issue throughout the play. They symbolize the way her tyrannical personality and obsession with family honor suck the fun, freedom, and aspiration out of her daughters’ lives. While Adela’s love for color represents her youth, energy, and desire for love, Bernarda’s insistence on black shows that she does the opposite: she defines herself entirely relative to men, through her social role as a widow, and entirely loses her sense of individuality and ability to enjoy life in the process.

☞ MAGDALENA: Neither mine nor yours. I know I’m not going to get married. I’d rather carry sacks to the mill. Anything but sit in this dark room, day after day!

BERNARDA: That’s what it means to be a woman.

MAGDALENA: To hell with being a woman!

BERNARDA: Here you do what I tell you to do! You can’t run to your father with your stories anymore. A needle and thread for females; a mule and a whip for males. That’s how it is for people born with means.

Related Characters: Bernarda Alba, Magdalena (speaker), Amelia

Related Themes:    

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 205-206

Explanation and Analysis

This passage offers one of the first clear signs of how Bernarda imposes traditional gender and class norms onto her daughters, to their detriment. All of Bernarda’s daughters, with the possible exception of Amelia, are in some way profoundly dissatisfied with the social role that their mother and society assign them. Magdalena expresses her dissatisfaction by asserting her independence and entirely rejecting the conventional social role of a woman in her society, which revolves around marriage. She concludes that it is better to die single than subject oneself to men’s control (and mistreatment). But since Bernarda’s overriding obsession in life is to preserve the family’s status by marrying her daughters off to acceptable men, she flatly rejects Magdalena’s wishes and insists that she has no choice but to marry. “People born with means”—those who belong to the upper classes, like Bernarda and her family—simply do not have any choice. Women are destined to spend their lives inside, embroidering with “a needle and thread,” and men take “a mule and a whip” to spend their days overseeing their fields. Of course, readers and audiences may see the irony in this: like most of her sisters, Magdalena has no realistic prospects within her village, particularly if she wants to marry someone of her same social class.

☞ PONCIA: No one can talk to you. Can we or can we not be honest with each other?

BERNARDA: We cannot. You are my servant, and I pay you. Nothing more!

Related Characters: Bernarda Alba, Poncia (speaker), Angustias

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 212

Explanation and Analysis

Halfway through Act I, Poncia asks about Angustias's marriage prospects, and Bernarda replies by complaining that there are no suitably high-class men in their village, but she also won't send her daughters away to marry anyone from another village. This is the exchange that follows. Poncia asks if they can be honest because she wants to tell Bernarda what everyone else has already realized: that by demanding the impossible for her daughters, Bernarda is setting them up for failure—or, at the very least, spinsterhood. This is the last thing that Bernarda wants, but she doesn't seem to understand that she will have to compromise in some way if she wants to get her daughters married.

Despite carrying decades' worth of resentment, Poncia approaches Bernarda cautiously and politely. Her goal is not to insult or discourage Bernarda—or even to tell her what she really thinks of the family. Rather, Poncia genuinely cares about Bernarda and her daughters' wellbeing, partially out of goodwill and partially because her own reputation depends on that of the family that employs her.

However, Bernarda chooses denial over knowledge. She cites their boss-employee relationship—which is really a reflection of their class differences—as an excuse for not taking Poncia's ideas seriously. This shows how Bernarda's sense of superiority is self-defeating—as is the broader traditional honor code that it reflects. Because she occupies a position of power in her household and community, she assumes that she knows what is best and nobody else has any ideas worth considering. As a result, she ruins her daughters' lives and remains blind to the real dynamics in her family throughout the whole play—including at its tragic conclusion.

☞ MARTIRIO: No. But things have a way of repeating themselves. And I see how it all follows a terrible pattern. And she'll suffer the same fate as her mother and her grandmother—the two wives of the man who fathered her.

Related Characters: Martirio (speaker), Bernarda Alba, Amelia

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 214

Explanation and Analysis

Amelia and Martirio are discussing a friend from the village, Adelaida, who has recently gotten engaged to a dreadful man who forbids her to leave the house. (This is why she didn't attend Don Antonio's funeral.) Martirio notes that Adelaida's father was also a terrible womanizer: he had two wives (one of whose original husband he murdered) and several affairs (one of which produced Adelaida). Recognizing this parallel, Martirio laments that history appears to be repeating itself. Women born of violent relationships are entering violent relationships because, in a society that treats them as property and defines their worth through their fathers and brothers, they have no true alternative.

Martirio's analysis of this "terrible pattern" shows how patriarchal traditions imprison women in an endless cycle of powerlessness and unfreedom, which does not seem to change from generation to generation. While women like Bernarda become resigned to this fate, others—like many of her daughters—dream of breaking the cycle and achieving true independence. Yet they get stuck in a catch-22: they cannot escape the cycle until society permits them to be anything but virgins, wives, or widows, but they also cannot change those norms unless they start to live differently.

☞ ADELA: I'm thinking that this period of mourning has caught me at the worst possible time.

MAGDALENA: You'll soon get used to it.

ADELA: (*Bursting into angry tears*) I will not get used to it! I don't want to be locked up! I don't want my body to dry up like yours! I don't want to waste away and grow old in these rooms. Tomorrow, I'll put on my green dress and go walking down the street. I want to get out!

Related Characters: Magdalena, Adela (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 220

Explanation and Analysis

At just 20 years old, Adela struggles to accept the notion

that she will have to spend the next eight years of her life locked inside, mourning her father's death. She expected to spend her twenties enjoying her youth, falling in love, and making the most of whatever limited degree of freedom could be available to her in her small rural village. Instead, thanks to her mother's insistence on following a strict, increasingly outdated honor code, she will see nothing but the inside of the family house and meet no one but her mother, sisters, and servants.

Magdalena, who is 10 years Adela's senior, has already resigned herself to the limits that village life will impose on her. But Adela continues to dream. After all, she desires to leave the house and wear her green dress—whose color contrasts with the black and white palette that dominates the rest of the play, and that represents the limited options available to women in her time and place. García Lorca places Adela's desire for freedom and love at the center of his play because she allows him to show how stifling rural, conservative culture is to women. Indeed, her conflict with her mother is in part a metaphor for young Spaniards' attempts to free themselves from the oppressive social currents that will soon lead to the civil war and Franco dictatorship.

☛☛ BERNARDA: Help her! All of you!

(They all drag the old woman off the stage)

MARIA JOSEFA: I want to get away from here! Bernarda! To get married at the edge of the sea, at the edge of the sea!

FAST CURTAIN

Related Characters: Bernarda Alba, Maria Josefa (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 225

Explanation and Analysis

Act 1 of *The House of Bernarda Alba* ends with Bernarda's senile mother Maria Josefa escaping from her interior bedroom and proclaiming that she wishes she could move far away and get married. All of the other women in the house band together to lock her back inside.

This is a jarring sequence, especially since Bernarda's daughters share Maria Josefa's dream of freeing themselves by marrying and leaving the village. Nevertheless, they carry out their mother's orders to lock their grandmother up, which demonstrates how women end up enforcing patriarchy and perpetuating their own

oppression in male-dominated rural Spain. Bernarda's decision to imprison her mother deep within her house carries important symbolism. It represents the way Bernarda mistreats her family in an attempt to make them conform to traditional social expectations and the way she locks away her desire for freedom, independence, and self-expression to ensure that it will not interfere with those social expectations.

Act 2 Quotes

☛☛ PONCIA: Afterwards, he behaved himself. Instead of doing something else, he took up breeding finches—until he died. Anyway, it's best for single women like you to know that fifteen days after the wedding a man leaves the bed for the table, then the table for the tavern. And any woman who doesn't accept it rots away crying in a corner!

Related Characters: Poncia (speaker), Bernarda Alba, Angustias, Pepe el Romano

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 231

Explanation and Analysis

The opening sequence in Act 2 demonstrates how Poncia has become the five sisters' confidant and substitute mother figure. She listens to them discuss Pepe and Angustias's budding relationship and offers advice based on her own marriage. She admits that her husband lied, cheated, and drank, but she supposes that all men do the same. As she explains here, given men's disproportionate power and the social norms that excuse their behavior, women have no choice but to accept unreliable, unworthy men. In turn, this grim reality feeds those damaging social norms by teaching men that there are no consequences for misbehavior and convincing women not to stop it.

Yet Poncia considers her husband a good man, all things considered, because he actually reined in his behavior once she hit him and killed his finches. Her anecdote demonstrates how married women can exert some influence on their husbands and thus achieve some limited degree of power—although still not the attention, equality, and freedom that they truly deserve. While Poncia is not cruel or classist like Bernarda, she is still clearly a traditionalist when it comes to gender roles, and she tries to convince Bernarda's daughters that they can still live worthwhile lives despite the virtual certainty that any marriage they enter will be unhappy.

☛ ADELA: She follows me everywhere. Sometimes she peeks into my room to see if I'm asleep. She won't let me breathe! And it's always, "What a shame about that face!" "What a shame about that body, which will never belong to anyone!" No! My body will be for anyone I please.

Related Characters: Adela (speaker), Bernarda Alba, Martirio, Poncia, Pepe el Romano

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 234

Explanation and Analysis

Adela tells Poncia that Martirio seems to be watching her, which makes her deeply uncomfortable. She dreams of having the privacy necessary to live in peace and make her own choices without judgment, but her sister seems to be jealous of her beauty and youth. (As readers and audiences will soon learn, Martirio is primarily jealous of Pepe's interest in Adela.) Most of all, Adela hates Martirio's comments about her future: Martirio suggests that Adela will never be able to marry. First, this is true of all of the sisters besides Angustias: they have no realistic prospects in the village and Bernarda forbids them to leave. And second, Adela rejects the notion that she ought to give a man control of her body, and that her value as a woman depends on whom she "belong[s] to."

Adela protests Martirio's obsession with her by insisting that "my body will be for anyone I please." Poncia knows that she's talking about her feelings for Pepe. Thus, Adela's line both foreshadows the later revelations about her adultery and serves as a protest against the traditional value system that her society (and most of all her mother Bernarda) forces upon her.

☛ PONCIA: Besides, who says you can't marry him? Your sister Angustias is sickly. She won't survive her first childbirth. She's narrow in the hips, old, and from what I know, I can tell she'll die. Then Pepe will do what all widowers do in this country: he'll marry the youngest, the most beautiful, and that will be you. Live on that hope or forget him, whatever you want: just don't go against the law of God!

Related Characters: Poncia (speaker), Bernarda Alba, Angustias, Adela, Pepe el Romano

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 236

Explanation and Analysis

Once Adela's interest in Pepe becomes clear, Poncia offers the cynical suggestion that Adela let Pepe and Angustias's marriage go forward—but hope to become his second wife when Angustias inevitably dies in childbirth. This may sound like a cruel joke, but it's not. To Poncia, this outcome would be acceptable because it would not involve adultery ("go[ing] against the law of God"). Modern readers and audiences might find this shocking—and to some extent, that was García Lorca's point. He suggests that only an inhumane system could celebrate behavior so cruel and manipulative as hoping one's sister dies. And yet traditional gender roles in rural Spain inevitably led women to seek solutions like these if they wanted love in addition to marriage. Her comment that "all widowers" marry young, attractive women reflects a low but likely realistic opinion of the men surrounding her. These thankless circumstances explain perfectly well how someone can become like Bernarda: at once jaded about romance, desperate to marry off her daughters, and tyrannical to anyone who defies her.

☛ ADELA: (*Sitting down*) Oh, if only I could go out to the fields, too!

MAGDALENA: (*Sitting down*) Each class does what it must.

MARTIRIO: (*Sitting down*) That's how it is.

(AMELIA *sits down with a sigh*)

PONCIA: There's no greater joy than being in the fields at this time of year! Yesterday morning the harvesters arrived. Forty or fifty good-looking young men.

Related Characters: Magdalena, Martirio, Adela, Poncia (speaker), Bernarda Alba

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 240

Explanation and Analysis

It's harvest time in the family's village, and the sisters struggle with the knowledge that dozens of "good-looking young men" have come from far away to work on their land, but they are not allowed to meet them. Since they belong to a traditional upper-class family, they cannot be seen in the fields, not to mention mingling with common field hands. (Worse still, they are supposed to be mourning for the next eight years, which means they cannot even leave the house.)

But they want nothing more than to meet men their age, something that their rigid mother and cloistered lifestyle make all but impossible.

As a result, in a curious inversion of conventional literary tropes, the sisters actually end up wishing they belonged to a lower social class. Just as Poncia envies their wealth, they envy lower-class women's relative freedom. Namely, since lower-class women must work to survive and don't depend on honor and reputation to the same degree for their social status, they have greater freedom in choosing where to go and whom to marry. This peculiar state of affairs shows how Spain's rigid traditional class system hurts *all* women, regardless of where they actually fall in the hierarchy.

●● AMELIA: To be born a woman is the worst punishment.

Related Characters: Amelia (speaker), Bernarda Alba, Magdalena, Adela

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 241

Explanation and Analysis

Amelia is the quietest of Bernarda's daughters and the least significant to the play's unfolding action. However, she still provides an interesting window into rural Spanish womanhood because, unlike the other sisters, she largely follows in her mother's footsteps. She takes life at face value, preferring not to challenge social norms, feel deep feelings, or think about complex topics.

Most notably, Amelia also utters this line, which is one of the play's most famous and incisive. Seeing the constraints that women face in her society, she concludes that not only is it better to be a man, but womanhood is actually a kind of punishment—perhaps God's punishment for sin. At the same time, unlike her sisters, she doesn't see any way out of this predicament. While Adela tries to escape the burdens of womanhood by pursuing love on her own terms and Magdalena tries to do so by refusing to take any interest in men at all, for instance, Amelia treats “be[ing] born a woman” as a “punishment” that she simply must endure, whether she likes it or not. In this sense, her attitude closely resembles her mother's: Bernarda also accepts traditional gender norms as inviolate and simply accepts that she must do what is asked for her as a woman, no matter how limiting or unpleasant it is. Amelia's attitude toward gender thus shows how oppressive norms get passed down from parent

to child over generations. Arguably, Bernarda and her daughters' misfortune in this play all stems from their being alone, without men, in a society that only values women through their connections to men.

●● PONCIA: (*With unrelenting cruelty*) Bernarda, something monstrous is happening here. I don't want to blame you, but you haven't allowed your daughters any freedom. Martirio is romantic, no matter what you say. Why didn't you let her marry Enrique Humanas? Why did you send him a message not to come to her window, the very day he was coming?

BERNARDA: (*Loud*) And I would do it a thousand times again! My blood will never mix with that of the Humanas family—not as long as I live! His father was a field hand.

PONCIA: This is what comes of putting on airs!

BERNARDA: I do because I can afford to! And you don't because you know very well what you come from.

Related Characters: Bernarda Alba, Poncia (speaker), Martirio, Adela

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 253

Explanation and Analysis

Having noticed the rising tension between Martirio and Adela, Poncia finally confronts Bernarda and warns her about the consequences of keeping her daughters under lock and key. She particularly notes how Bernarda seeded Martirio's jealousy in the play's present by rejecting her suitor Enrique Humanas on the grounds of class. But while audiences can easily connect the dots between Poncia's explanation and Martirio's increasingly open animosity for Adela, Bernarda stops processing it the moment class comes up. For Bernarda, mixing with commoners is a red line that cannot be crossed, as it would automatically mean permanent reputational damage to the family. As Bernarda points out Poncia's low birth in an attempt to silence her, it grows increasingly clear that no amount of rational argument will ever get through to her. Rather, since she considers reputation more important than anything else, including life itself and her daughters' happiness, she stands by her decision—and would still let her family implode before letting her daughter marry a commoner. Her obsession with reputation and indifference to her daughters' happiness are two sides of the same coin, and García Lorca uses them to suggest that rural Spain's

stubborn, traditional value system distorts people's priorities and undermines their humanity.

☞☞ (*Outside, a woman screams, and there is a great uproar*)

ADELA: They should let her go! Don't go out there!

MARTIRIO: (*Looking at ADELA*) Let her pay for what she did.

BERNARDA: (*In the archway*) Finish her off before the Civil Guard gets here! Burning coals in the place where she sinned!

ADELA: (*Clutching her womb*) No! No!

BERNARDA: Kill her! Kill her!

CURTAIN

Related Characters: Bernarda Alba, Martirio, Adela (speaker), Maria Josefa, Pepe el Romano

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 261

Explanation and Analysis

Act 2 of *The House of Bernarda Alba* ends with a jarring, unexpected event that portends the tragedy that will soon befall Bernarda's family. After catching a young woman killing and hiding the body of a child she bore out of wedlock, a mob of townspeople abducted her and started dragging her down the main road. They will likely kill or torture her as punishment. Upon learning this, Bernarda starts to enthusiastically cry out in support and even describe the horrible punishments she hopes the woman will suffer (like "burning coals" on her genitals). This horrifies Adela, who not only has been carrying on an affair with her sister's fiancé Pepe el Romano but is also pregnant with his child (which she signals to the audience by holding her womb).

Like the scene of Maria Josefa's escape at the end of Act 1, this scene carries a great symbolic importance to the play, even though it is disconnected from the overall narrative. First, it foreshadows the end of the play, in which Martirio reveals Adela's adultery, Bernarda tries to shoot Pepe, and Adela commits suicide. In fact, this scene may explain why Adela ultimately chooses to hang herself: she thinks that the alternative will be torture at her mother's hand (and she doesn't realize that Bernarda would probably choose to lie to protect her family's reputation instead).

Second, this scene underlines the brutality and injustice in rural Spain's honor code for women. Even as Bernarda claims to be more civilized than everyone else in her village because she is wealthier by birth and hews closely to the

church's rules, this scene shows that her beliefs can easily translate into an animalistic bloodlust that nobody would associate with upper-class refinement. Arguably, this barbaric impulse to violence is the central emotion underlying her authoritarian personality, as well as the culture she represents more broadly. If such an ethos truly lurks behind much of Spanish culture, it's little surprise that the nation's government would soon be seized by a right-wing dictatorship set on eliminating people it deemed socially undesirable—including García Lorca—through mass murder.

Act 3 Quotes

☞☞ PRUDENCIA: It's lovely. Three pearls! In my day, pearls meant tears.

ANGUSTIAS: But things have changed now.

ADELA: I don't think so. Things always mean the same. Engagement rings are supposed to be diamonds.

PRUDENCIA: It's more appropriate.

Related Characters: Angustias, Adela, Prudencia (speaker), Pepe el Romano

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 266

Explanation and Analysis

Bernarda's friend and neighbor Prudencia visits for dinner at the beginning of Act 3. Oddly, rather than discussing the late Don Antonio's funeral, their conversation revolves around Prudencia's family's reputation, the church, and Angustias's upcoming marriage to Pepe el Romano. But when Angustias shows Prudencia her wedding ring, this is the conversation that follows. Unable to restrain herself, Prudencia notes that pearls are traditionally associated with tears. She thus implies that a pearl wedding ring is a bad omen for a couple. Ironically, the sister least beholden to tradition, Adela, is the first to jump to Prudencia's defense. But she clearly does so because she is also involved with Pepe and doesn't want Angustias to marry him, and not because she actually believes in Prudencia's superstition about pearls. Prudencia and Adela agree that the best gemstone for a ring is the more traditional—and more expensive—diamond. Of course, Pepe's unwillingness or inability to pay for a diamond is also a bad omen for Angustias, because it suggests that he is not truly as invested in their relationship as he would like to make it

seem.

Through this conversation, gemstones become another site for the family's ongoing conflict over what role tradition should play in their lives, and whether important cultural symbols mean what they used to as other elements of life start to change in the village. As with clothing colors, mourning rituals, and the rules for picking a husband, the sisters' breaks from tradition look like freedom to them but a fall from grace to their mother (and others of her generation).

☞ BERNARDA: You shouldn't ask him. Especially after you're married. Speak if he speaks, and look at him when he looks at you. That way, you won't quarrel.

ANGUSTIAS: Mother, I think he hides many things from me.

BERNARDA: Don't try to find out about them. Don't ask him. And, above all, don't ever let him see you cry.

ANGUSTIAS: I should be happy, and I'm not.

Related Characters: Bernarda Alba, Angustias (speaker), Pepe el Romano

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 269

Explanation and Analysis

Angustias voices her concerns about her upcoming marriage to Bernarda, who ignores and overrides her. Bernarda belligerently insists that a woman's role is to obey her husband and accept her lot in life, no matter how unhappy this makes her. She proposes her own favorite strategy, denial, as the solution for any dissonance between one's dreams and one's reality. This illustrates not only the grim reality of womanhood in early 20th-century rural Spain, but also the great lengths to which women like Bernarda went in an effort to convince themselves that this reality was normal and acceptable.

Bernarda's disappointing advice makes it abundantly clear that she views her daughter primarily as a pawn in a social game, as someone to get married as soon as possible and not someone whose fate, feelings, and freedom have any value in themselves. Of course, this grim vision of married life only scares Angustias further, as it shows her that she will be sacrificing the little degree of autonomy she still has—not to mention her substantial inheritance—if she goes forward with the wedding.

☞ ADELA: Mother, when there's a shooting star or a flash of lightning, why do we say:

Blessed Santa Barbara, why
Are you writing, up so high,
With holy water in the sky?

BERNARDA: In the old days they knew many things that we have forgotten.

AMELIA: I close my eyes so I won't see them!

ADELA: Not me. I like to see things blazing through the sky, after being motionless year after year.

Related Characters: Bernarda Alba, Amelia, Adela (speaker), Pepe el Romano

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 272

Explanation and Analysis

The sisters look up at the stars, which come to symbolize their own desire to free themselves from their mother, village, and society's constraints. Curious, freethinking Adela asks Bernarda why they traditionally associate shooting stars with Saint Barbara, and to her dismay, Bernarda has no idea. She trusts such traditions on their own merits. But her inability to explain beliefs she holds so blindly and fanatically suggests that the whole edifice of tradition in rural Spain is really just an elaborate justification for domination, particularly by men and the church.

The lines that follow from Adela and Amelia further underline the tension between tradition and modernity, constraint and freedom, or conformity and independence that sustain the narrative arc of this play. Adela's line about "see[ing] things blazing through the sky, after being motionless" clearly represents her desire for freedom. She refers to overcoming the "motionless" life that she and her sisters are forced to live in Bernarda's house, as well as in a society that treats them more like property than human beings. And her reference to shooting stars "blazing through the sky," moving suddenly and bombastically after a lifetime of motionlessness, serves as a metaphor for the personal fulfillment and freedom from social constraints that she seeks through her relationship with Pepe.

On the other hand, Amelia is like her mother Bernarda: she prefers not to see things that she does not understand, or that point her to possibilities beyond the limits of her current, cloistered life. But this limits her. Throughout the

play, García Lorca shows that this kind of willful ignorance perpetuates itself in a vicious cycle: by accepting male domination and refusing to imagine themselves as free, women only strengthen that domination and reduce their chances of ever achieving freedom.

☞ PONCIA: There's nothing I can do. I tried to put a stop to all this, but now it frightens me too much. Do you hear this silence? Well, there's a storm brewing in every room. The day it bursts, we'll all be swept away! I've said what I had to say.

Related Characters: Poncia (speaker), Bernarda Alba, Martirio, Adela, The Maid

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 276

Explanation and Analysis

After the family goes to bed, Poncia admits to the Maid that she has given up on trying to save Bernarda's daughters. Every time she has tried to point out the obvious conflict between Martirio and Adela, Bernarda has rebuffed and insulted her instead of listening to what she had to say. The more explicitly Poncia tries to point out the problem, the more severely Bernarda responds, and so Poncia has finally admitted that there is nothing more she can do. She knows that the coming "storm" will tear the family apart, and she awaits it with dread because, whether she likes it or not, she also depends on Bernarda's family for her livelihood, reputation, and sense of purpose. In this way, Poncia becomes a guide to and substitute for the play's audience, who also know that Bernarda's stubbornness will lead the family to ruin before this final act of the play is over.

☞ MARIA JOSEFA: It's true. Everything is very dark. Just because I have white hair you think I can't have babies. And—yes! Babies and babies and babies! This child will have white hair, and have another child, and that one, another, and all of us with hair of snow will be like the waves, one after another after another. Then we'll all settle down, and we'll all have white hair, and we'll be foam on the sea. Why isn't there any white foam here? Here there's nothing but black mourning shawls.

Related Characters: Maria Josefa (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 280

Explanation and Analysis

Two-thirds of the way through the play's final act, Bernarda's mother Maria Josefa again escapes from her room. This time, she is holding a baby ewe she has taken from the corral, and she sings and gives a monologue describing her dream of escaping Bernarda's house and village, going to the seashore, marrying a handsome man, having babies, and starting a new bloodline. The hypothetical babies' white hair not only makes them resemble Maria Josefa and confirms that her dream is impossible, but also associates them with the life, innocence, birth, and virginity that white represents throughout the play. This contrasts with the "black mourning shawls" that represent the staleness and unfreedom of life in Bernarda's house.

Of course, this is all only a fantasy: she is old and senile, and she already has a family—Bernarda and her daughters, whom she clearly doesn't much like. On one level, Maria Josefa's fantasy represents the common dream that unites everyone in the play, with the possible exception of Magdalena: a blissful marriage that fulfills women's need for genuine love and freedom, without forcing them to shirk social expectations of female subservience and family honor. On another, perhaps Maria Josefa is lamenting the mistakes she made in her youth: perhaps she wishes that she had married a man from the coast, instead of marrying Bernarda's father in the inland village where she and her descendants are now stuck.

☞ MARTIRIO: (*Pointing at ADELA*) She was with him! Look at her petticoats, covered with straw!

BERNARDA: That is the bed of sinful women! (*She moves toward ADELA, furious*)

ADELA: (*Confronting her*) The shouting in this prison is over! (*She seizes her mother's cane and breaks it in two*) This is what I do with the tyrant's rod! Don't take one step more. No one gives me orders but Pepe!

Related Characters: Bernarda Alba, Martirio, Adela (speaker), Pepe el Romano

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 285

Explanation and Analysis

At the end of the play, Martirio tells Adela that she no longer views her as a sister, then calls over their mother Bernarda and points out the straw on Adela's petticoats. In this play, adultery is strongly associated with animalistic desire and natural settings, like the olive grove where the field hands take women, sometimes with and sometimes without their consent. Given this link, Bernarda and the audience can reliably interpret the straw on Adela's petticoats as evidence of adultery. Now finally exposed, Adela knows that her mother's wrath would ordinarily await her. After all, her adultery is a stain not just on her personal honor, but on her whole family's honor, likely for generations in either direction.

Instead of waiting for her mother to make the first move, Adela takes decisive action: she breaks the cane that Bernarda uses to beat her daughters, symbolically overthrowing her tyrannical power. Of course, her admission of adultery represents the same process, just on a different level, because it means she no longer accepts the social honor codes that Bernarda uses to terrorize her daughters. But curiously, rather than declaring that she will make her own decisions, Adela instead insists that *Pepe* is her new master. In other words, she does not liberate herself, but only chooses a new overlord. Still, readers and audiences may view Adela's rebellion as a metaphor for the democratic overthrow of Spain's king a half-decade before García Lorca wrote this play.

🔊 (A shot is heard)

BERNARDA: (*Entering*) I dare you to find him now!

MARTIRIO: (*Entering*) That's the end of Pepe el Romano!

ADELA: Pepe! My God! Pepe! (*She runs out of the room*)

Related Characters: Bernarda Alba, Martirio, Adela (speaker), Poncia, Pepe el Romano

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 286

Explanation and Analysis

Shortly after Adela admits to having had sex with Pepe, Bernarda realizes that Pepe is waiting just behind the house, in the corral. Bernarda takes her gun, runs into the corral with Martirio, and fires at Pepe. Although she misses—and he rides off into the night on his horse,

presumably never to return—Martirio spitefully suggests to Adela that they have killed Pepe. (Some might interpret her as only saying that Pepe won't be in the family's lives anymore, but after the gunshot, her implication is clearly murder.)

Upon realizing that she can no longer leave her family for Pepe, Adela runs into her room and hangs herself. While Bernarda, Pepe, and Adela herself are all partially responsible for the play's tragic conclusion in differing ways, it's nevertheless clear that Martirio's lie is the decisive turning point. In this way, the play's final scene fulfills Poncia's prediction that Adela and Martirio's rivalry would explode into violence and suggests that the only way Adela can truly maintain her independence, resist her family's control, and unite herself with her seemingly fallen lover is through death. Of course, García Lorca likely did not mean to romanticize suicide—Adela hangs herself in response to lies, not as a reaction to the truth, and she certainly could have run away to be with Pepe if she had chosen to live instead.

🔊 BERNARDA: I want no weeping. We must look death in the face. Silence! (*To another daughter*) Be quiet, I said! (*To another daughter*) Tears, when you're alone. We will all drown ourselves in a sea of mourning. The youngest daughter of Bernarda Alba has died a virgin. Did you hear me? Silence! Silence, I said! Silence!

CURTAIN

Related Characters: Bernarda Alba (speaker), Adela, Pepe el Romano, Antonio María Benavides

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 288

Explanation and Analysis

The House of Bernarda Alba ends with its title character repeating her first line from the play: "Silence!" Earlier, she yelled "Silence!" to demand her daughters and servants mourn her late husband Antonio according to her wishes. Here, she is doing the same for her daughter Adela, who has just committed suicide. Curiously, Bernarda falsely claims that Adela "has died a virgin." Bernarda saw the straw on Adela's petticoat, accused her of sin, and shot at her paramour Pepe el Romano, so there's no doubt that she knows—or at least knew—the truth. It is unclear whether she has truly forgotten, is in denial, or simply wants to control the narrative that will inevitably spread around her

village. While Bernarda may think she is doing Adela a favor by falsely remembering her as a virgin, she is also insulting Adela's memory by refusing to see the truth—and acknowledge the freedom that Adela died for, her refusal to live by oppressive patriarchal norms. Indeed, Bernarda's announcement about Adela's virginity shows that her obsession with purity and sin has left her profoundly disconnected from reality and unable to truly confront the darkness that she has created in her family.

It's also no coincidence that García Lorca has Bernarda repeat the line "Silence!" On one level of analysis, this points to the eternal nothingness of death, the voicelessness of those beyond the grave, and the way that rural Spain's

stifling traditional culture creates a cycle of tragedy. (This is why the play starts and ends with death and mourning.) On another level, Bernarda's demand for "Silence!" also reflects her unending impulse to control everyone around her—quite literally to silence their voices—in an attempt to dominate her daughters and shape others' opinions of her family.

Lastly, to contemporary readers, audiences, and critics, this final word of García Lorca's final play unwittingly predicted his own untimely death and the chilling censorship that would befall Spain for the next four decades, suppressing free expression there until the end of the Franco dictatorship in 1975.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

ACT 1

Church bells toll in a small southern Spanish village. The Maid starts cleaning Bernarda Alba's **white** sitting room and remarks that the noise is giving her a headache. Poncia follows her inside, eating a sausage, and notes that Magdalena fainted at her father's funeral; she was his favorite. They share snacks in secret because Bernarda is in mourning and refuses to eat. Someone (Maria Josefa) yells out Bernarda's name; the Maid rushes to open Maria Josefa's locked bedroom door while Poncia explains that Bernarda "tyrannizes everyone around her." In fact, Bernarda's husband's family came to the funeral, but didn't want anything to do with their daughter-in-law.

Poncia laments that she has obediently cared for Bernarda for the last 30 years—ever since Bernarda's father died. The whole time, Bernarda has scarcely left the house and spent all her time gossiping about the neighbors. Poncia dreams of telling Bernarda how she really feels, and she complains that Bernarda's "five ugly daughters" won't inherit much of anything. Still, they're much wealthier than Poncia and the Maid. Poncia leaves to hear the last prayer in the church; she loves the priest's singing voice.

As the Maid cleans, a beggar woman enters, asking for Bernarda's leftovers. But the Maid says she is keeping them for herself, and she kicks the woman out of the house. She curses Bernarda's late husband, Antonio, who used to lift up her skirt. But then, all the mourning women enter the house. The Maid starts wailing and praising Antonio instead. Bernarda furiously tells her to stop screaming, work harder, and then get out. The Maid leaves. Bernarda comments that "the poor are like animals" and screams at the mourners who disagree.

It's telling that García Lorca chooses to introduce Bernarda Alba, her family, and her house through the eyes of the play's three most peripheral characters: Poncia, the Maid, and Maria Josefa. This reflects Bernarda's tyrannical rule over the house, her blindness to the power dynamics in her family, and the central role that gossip, reputation, and honor play in her village. Similarly, the church bells and the house's white walls represent the village's conservatism, and Maria Josefa's confinement to her bedroom reflects how tradition renders all of the play's women unfree.



Poncia demonstrates that she is the play's voice of reason, the only person who truly understands the family dynamics that harm Bernarda's daughters and ultimately lead them to tragedy. But Poncia also recognizes that, because of rural Spain's strict class system, she depends entirely on Bernarda and can never share what she really thinks. But Poncia's feelings about the priest show that she still believes in Spain's traditional social hierarchy, even if she recognizes the injustice baked into it.



Poncia and the Maid were clearly right about Bernarda's explosive, tyrannical temperament. The Maid's cruel response to the beggar woman parallels Bernarda's cruelty towards the Maid, which she also justifies on the basis of social class. This shows that, even though the Maid belongs to the bottom rungs of the village's social hierarchy, this hierarchy is so all-consuming that she still accepts and enforces it. The Maid's revelation about Antonio complicates the image Bernarda projects of him as a pure, ideal husband—but later events in the play will make it clear that his philandering is the norm, rather than the exception, in rural Spain.



Poncia brings lemonade. Bernarda tells her to give some to the men outside, too—but not to let them come in. Bernarda curses the unholy women who look at men (besides the priest) at church, then leads the other women in a prayer and sees them out the door. Poncia brings a sack of money from the men, and Bernarda tells the weeping Magdalena to be quiet. She yells that the mourning women should never return to her house, which they have defiled.

Bernarda's insistence on separating men and women reflects rural Spain's strict patriarchal norms: no man can enter Antonio's house while the women of his family are still mourning him. Similarly, Bernarda's condemnation of women who look at men in church, one of the few places where genders mix in rural 1930s Spain, reflects her attempts to control her daughters' sexual and romantic desires. Her desire to preserve the orderly appearance of mourning ironically leads her to silence Magdalena, the only person who truly loved Antonio and is mourning him sincerely.



Bernarda makes her youngest daughter Adela give her a fan, but she throws it on the ground because it is red and green, and not a widow's **black**. The fourth daughter, Martirio, says she isn't warm and offers her fan; but Bernarda says that Martirio will need a new one because they won't be opening the doors or windows for the traditional "eight years of mourning." She tells Magdalena to spend this time **embroidering** her *ajuar* (the clothes and linens that a woman traditionally makes in preparation for her wedding). But Magdalena says she doesn't care because she doesn't plan to marry. But all women have to marry, Bernarda says. Magdalena responds, "to hell with being a woman!" Bernarda repeats that Magdalena has no choice.

Bernarda clearly treats her daughters with the same cruelty that she does Poncia and the Maid. For instance, she makes demands on them but rejects their efforts as inadequate, and she insists that they sacrifice eight years of their youth mourning in the service of outdated social codes. Arguably, Bernarda is more interested in asserting power over her daughters than actually maintaining harmony in her family. Adela's red fan is an important symbol: throughout the play, García Lorca associates her rebelliousness with color. This contrasts with everything else, which, at Bernarda's insistence, is either a virgin's white or a widow's black. Like Adela, Magdalena also tries to resist the social codes Bernarda imposes on her: she concludes that, if being a woman means playing by Bernarda's rules, she would rather not play at all.



The Maid enters from Bernarda's mother Maria Josefa's room. Maria Josefa is 80 but still strong, the Maid explains, and kept screaming during the funeral to ask for "dishwater [...] and dog meat," which she says is all Bernarda gives her. At Bernarda's orders, the Maid takes Maria Josefa out to the courtyard, by the well. Adela reports that Bernarda's oldest daughter, Angustias, was peeking out the door at the men. Bernarda yells that a respectable woman would never chase men after her father's funeral. Angustia denies doing this, but Bernarda starts beating Angustias with her cane. All the daughters go, leaving Poncia and Bernarda alone.

Maria Josefa's complaints show that Bernarda does not offer her mother the same loyalty and attention she demands from her daughters. Indeed, they suggest that the family's women face the same predicament from generation to generation, as they sacrifice their freedom to uphold a traditional culture that oppresses them.



Poncia explains that Angustias was just innocently eavesdropping on the men; Bernarda wants to know about their conversation. Poncia says that the men were bragging about taking Paca la Roseta to the olive grove and having their way with her—supposedly with her consent. Bernarda calls Paca the town’s “only loose woman,” and Poncia says it’s “because she’s not from here.” Poncia asks when Angustias will marry; she’s already 39 and hasn’t had any suitors. Offended, Bernarda says that no men are good enough for her daughters for miles around, but she won’t take them elsewhere “to sell them.” Frustrated, Poncia asks if she and Bernarda can talk honestly; Bernarda says no because “you are my servant, and I pay you.”

The Maid enters to report that Don Arturo has come to talk about the will. Bernarda orders her to hide Antonio’s clothes and insists that they won’t part with any of his possessions. Bernarda and the Maid leave.

Amelia and Martirio enter the room. Amelia asks about Martirio’s medicine, which Martirio confirms she is taking. Martirio comments that their friend Adelaida didn’t attend the funeral because her fiancé forbids her to leave the house. Adelaida’s father is a horrible womanizer, Martirio explains, and her family history seems to be repeating itself. “It’s better never to lay eyes on a man,” Martirio comments, before lamenting how the man she once loved married a girl from a wealthier family instead. Magdalena arrives from the storage room, describes Maria Josefa’s old **embroidery**, and comments that life has gotten worse because everyone worries about their reputation now. She describes Adela wearing her green dress and yelling at the chickens; she laments that Adela, too, will have to give up her dreams.

Bernarda’s curiosity further reflects her hypocrisy: she chastises Angustias for gossiping, but she proves quite the gossip herself. The anecdote about Paca la Roseta illustrates how rural Spain’s gendered culture of honor blames women for failing to resist men’s impropriety and even sexual violence—which are treated as normal and inevitable. Meanwhile, Bernarda’s criteria for marrying her daughters are completely self-defeating: if there are no suitable men in the village, but her daughters also cannot leave, then they will simply never get married. This means that they will never be able to leave Bernarda’s house, achieve true freedom, or give birth to the next generation and pass on their family legacy—which is the entire point of Bernarda’s gendered honor code to begin with.



Bernarda’s concern about losing some of Antonio’s possessions suggests that, despite all her praise for him as an ideal husband, he may have other potential heirs elsewhere. This could include not only his side of the family, but also cherished friends, business associates, or even other wives, mistresses, and/or children. Bernarda’s behavior also shows that she is willing to subvert the norms of her culture’s moral code when it benefits her directly.



Adelaida’s fate shows that the choice between singlehood and marriage is a lose-lose proposition for Bernarda’s daughters: they must live under either their mother’s domination or their husbands’. By passing on such traditions from generation to generation, García Lorca suggests, Spanish women trap themselves in an unending cycle of unfreedom and unrealized potential. But like Magdalena, Martirio is jaded about men and willing to forego marriage. This means that she may be able to break the cycle of violence—but only by sacrificing the prospect of love.



Angustias walks across the stage. Magdalena reveals that Pepe el Romano wants to marry Angustias, and Amelia and Martirio say he's a good man, but Magdalena says he doesn't love her and only wants her money. (Angustias is actually the other four women's half-sister—her father was Bernarda's first husband, and she has inherited all his money.) Adela enters in her beautiful green dress, which she wishes she could wear outside. When she learns the news about Pepe and Angustias, she grows furious and declares that she *will* go outside. The Maid comes to report that Pepe is coming down the street, and the four sisters rush off to watch him.

Angustias is the ugliest, sickliest, and oldest of all the sisters. So Pepe el Romano's willingness to marry her for her wealth shows what really underlies Spain's traditional marriage codes: greed and the desire to accrue status through wealth. Adela gets angry at her sisters because she is also in love with Pepe. Indeed, while Magdalena and Martirio imagine reclaiming their freedom by rejecting love altogether, Adela pursues an even more radical alternative: she wants to affirm her freedom through her desire for love, and specifically for Pepe el Romano. Her green dress represents her refusal to follow the scripts set out for her by her mother and her society—and her resistance to the notion that virginity (white) and widowhood (black) are the only appropriate roles for a single woman.



Bernarda and Poncia enter and complain that Don Antonio left too much to Angustias in his will. Angustias enters and Bernarda criticizes her for powdering her face after the funeral. Angustias points out that Don Antonio was not her real father, and Bernarda angrily starts wiping the powder off her face. The other sisters return and ask what the fight is about. Magdalena mentions the inheritance; Bernarda insists that it's her house, and she will make the decisions.

Antonio left his wealth to the daughter who least needed it, and the only one who was not his by blood. While it's impossible to know his motives, since he is dead, there are many ways to interpret his decision. For instance, perhaps he knew that conflict over marriage would tear the family apart and figured that, by giving Angustias most of the money, he could save his biological daughters from the unhappy marriages that await women of their class.



The Maid enters with the elderly Maria Josefa, who insists that none of the other women can have her clothes “because none of you is going to get married.” Maria Josefa says she wants to go to the seaside or back to her village and get married. Bernarda chastises the Maid for letting Maria Josefa escape, and all of the women work together to drag the screaming Maria Josefa back into her room and lock her inside.

Like fool and lunatic characters throughout Western literature, Maria Josefa gets to speak the truth directly in a way that the play's other characters simply cannot. Her prediction that none of her granddaughters will marry foreshadows the play's conclusion, and her desire to return to her village reveals that she is not actually from the same village where she raised Bernarda. This is noteworthy because Bernarda consistently views outsiders as suspicious and immoral, and yet at the end of the play it becomes clear that her daughters will only be able to marry if they, too, leave their home village. In this sense, Maria Josefa's speech reveals Bernarda's entire rural Spanish value system as a farce. But the fact that all the women collaborate to lock her back in her room symbolizes how deep-set this value system is for all of them. In fact, imprisoning Maria Josefa in this way seems to be the only thing they agree on throughout the play.



ACT 2

Bernarda's daughters, except Adela, are **embroidering** with Poncia. As she embroiders sheets for Amelia, Magdalena jokes to Angustias that she is adding Pepe's initials. The women wonder why Adela hasn't come, and Angustias says she can't wait to move away. Poncia opens the door to stave off the summer heat. Magdalena and Amelia comment that they saw Pepe visiting Angustias the previous night, although they disagree about how late he stayed. Martirio says it's strange that Pepe would start approaching Angustias, even though they had never met before. Angustias explains that she knew why Pepe was coming, and he asked for her hand matter-of-factly, claiming he wanted a "well behaved" wife. Angustias was thrilled; she had never been alone with a man like that.

Poncia describes the first time her husband came to her window; they briefly chatted, then embraced through the window bars, then married. Like all men, Poncia's husband quickly grew tired of her. But it could have been much worse. All men cheat and drink, she laments, and women have to accept it. She hit him and even killed his beloved pet finches when he misbehaved. The other women laugh.

Magdalena goes to check on Adela, who Angustias says is envious and mad. Magdalena brings Adela inside, but Adela says she just feels sick. She tells the others to leave her alone and keep **embroidering**, and she complains that she can't go anywhere without all her sisters finding out. The Maid enters and reports that Bernarda wants them all; everyone leaves besides Poncia and Adela, who insults the departing Martirio.

Embroidery is the paramount female-coded activity for women of Bernarda's class, who were wealthy enough to avoid even housework. This is why Bernarda has ordered her daughters to spend their eight years of mourning embroidering their ajuares (wedding linens), which is of course a metaphor for their preparation for marriage. Thus, it's ironic that Magdalena—the sister least interested in marriage—takes the lead. This underlines how tradition is quickly becoming less relevant in Spain. Magdalena's joke to Adela about Pepe is also ironic, as they are the only two sisters who do not become involved with him in some way. Pepe's interest in a "well behaved" wife fits cleanly with the value system that Bernarda has taught her daughters, but it also suggests that he is interested in marrying for status rather than love. Readers and audiences must recall that Angustias is 39 years old, so her comment that she had never been alone with a man reflects just how sheltered and unfree Bernarda has kept her daughters throughout their lives.



Poncia's love story represents the typical romantic script for rural Spain in the 1930s: men propose to women quickly, treating the process almost like the acquisition of property, then just as quickly forget about them and go on with their immoral behavior. While Poncia's pushback to her husband shows that she had some power in her marriage, she still accepted his misbehavior and viewed her subordinate role in the marriage as proper.



To understand Adela's frustration, it is helpful to remember that she is just 20 years old, and her mother is demanding that she spend the next eight years of her life locked inside, mourning. Adela seems to just now be learning how scripted and restricted her life will be as a woman in rural Spain—something to which her sisters have long since resigned themselves. That said, there is clearly something else behind her anger, too: she is in love with Pepe el Romano and cannot stand the thought of him marrying Angustias instead.



Adela complains that Martirio constantly watches her and comments on her face and body. “My body will be for anyone I please,” Adela announces, and Poncia asks if she means Pepe el Romano. Poncia points out that Adela woke up and stood at the window when Pepe last visited Angustias, then comments that Angustias probably won’t survive childbirth and Pepe could remarry Adela afterward. Offended, Adela cries and screams at Poncia, who claims that she is just trying to prevent the family from falling into disgrace. Adela warns that Poncia won’t stop her and declares that whatever happens between her and Pepe is meant to be.

Angustias enters, and Adela and Poncia pretend they are just arguing about errands. Satisfied, Angustias leaves. Martirio, Amelia, and Magdalena enter and chat about Angustias’s **wedding lace**, but agree that they won’t go on sewing for Angustias if she chooses to have children.

The bells strike three o’clock, and men start returning home from the fields. The women wish they could go out and see the attractive young fieldhands, who have come from the mountains to work. But due to their class, the women must stay home. Poncia says that 15 of the fieldhands took a dancing-woman into the olive grove last night. Poncia concludes that “men need these things” (including her own son) and Amelia declares that “to be born a woman is the worst punishment.” In the distance, the fieldhands sing about harvesting wheat and seducing women. The sisters dream of being free to come and go as they please.

Adela, Magdalena, and Poncia go to watch the men out of Adela’s bedroom window. Meanwhile, Martirio tells Amelia that the summer heat is making her sick and asks if Amelia knows anything about the sounds she heard coming from the corral late at night. Amelia says that maybe it was just **a wild mule**, and Martirio slyly jokes that it must have been. Amelia starts to leave and Martirio calls out her name, but claims it was an accident.

Martirio and Adela view each other as rivals not only because they are the two youngest sisters, but also because they are both in love with Pepe. Adela suggests that she is willing to have sex with Pepe even outside the bounds of marriage, which is radical departure from the social norms in her community. Indeed, according to those norms, women’s bodies belong not to themselves but to their husbands—and yet men are free to sleep with whomever they want. Poncia offers Adela a clear but deeply cynical way to reconcile these norms with her desires by predicting that Angustias will die in childbirth, then Pepe will keep her wealth and marry Adela instead.



In Bernarda’s small, crowded house, misunderstandings abound because everything risks being overheard. The sisters’ reluctance to embroider for Angustias’s potential future children, instead of themselves, reflects their very real worry that Angustias will be the only one to marry because she is the only one with enough wealth to offer an adequate dowry.



This scene reflects the tragic dimension of class divisions in García Lorca’s rural Spain: just as Poncia wishes she had Bernarda’s family’s wealth, so that she wouldn’t have to spend her life working for them, the sisters wish they could have the freedom of lower-class women, who don’t have to lock themselves inside and stick to men of their own social class in order to keep up appearances. Still, Poncia’s comment about “men need[ing] these things” shows that women of her class are no more exempt from patriarchy.



Doors and windows again provide the sisters with their only connection to the outside world. Martirio’s comment about the corral is clearly a sexual reference. (It’s about Adela and Pepe.) But Amelia naïvely takes Martirio at face value. Having taken Bernarda’s values and the women’s honor code to heart more than any of her sisters, Amelia simply cannot—or chooses not to—see the salacious truth.



Angustias enters, furious that someone has stolen the picture of Pepe she kept under her pillow. Her sisters return, and Angustias confronts them. Bernarda comes in, too, and she declares that the neighbors will hear the sisters' argument. Angustias mentions the stolen photo and Bernarda sends Poncia to search the other sisters' rooms for it. Poncia returns shortly thereafter with the photo, which she says she found in Martirio's bed. Bernarda beats Martirio with her cane, but Angustias stops her. Martirio claims she was just playing a prank on her sister, but Adela insists that Martirio is in love with Pepe, too. Martirio declares that "the walls will collapse in shame" if she tells the truth.

The sisters all accuse one another of sin; Angustias reminds the others that Pepe el Romano chose her, but Adela, Martirio, and Magdalena declare that he just wants her money. Distraught, Bernarda kicks her daughters out of the room. She and Poncia agree that they have to get Angustias and Pepe married and "far away from here" as soon as possible. But Poncia speculates that Pepe won't leave; Bernarda objects and accuses Poncia of attacking her. "Open your eyes and you'll see," Poncia tells Bernarda; Bernarda seems to see everyone's flaws but her own daughters'. But Bernarda still insists that Martirio was just joking when she stole Angustias's picture of Pepe.

Poncia tells Bernarda that "something monstrous is happening here" and argues that Bernarda should have let Martirio marry her suitor Enrique Humanas, even if his father was merely a fieldhand. But Bernarda refuses to mix with a lower-class family and accuses Poncia of forgetting her own low birth. She insists that nothing is wrong in her house and declares that her family would never be caught dead in the brothel that Poncia's late mother used to run.

Poncia says she shouldn't have gotten involved in the family's problems, and Bernarda replies that her job is to "work and keep your mouth shut." But Poncia says that she felt the need to say something, and that it would be better for everyone if Pepe marries Adela—the woman he really loves. "Things are never the way we would like them to be," Bernarda quips, but Poncia replies that people always end up following their true desires. Bernarda accuses Poncia of inventing evil prophecies, but she reassures herself that her daughters would never disobey her. The real problem will come once they're independent, Poncia says, but Bernarda insists she'll overpower them.

Martirio's comment about her shame suggests that Adela is right: Martirio is also in love with Pepe, and her jealousy for Angustias and Adela has risen to the level of a veritable sibling rivalry. Readers and audiences should consider this in the context of Martirio's romantic history—and specifically the suitor who left her for a wealthier woman. Meanwhile, Bernarda's reaction to the situation shows that she values her family's reputation far more than her daughters' wellbeing: she cares more about whether the neighbors hear the sisters fighting than what they are actually arguing about.



Bernarda and Poncia hope to fix the sisters' conflict by rushing Angustias and Pepe's marriage, so there is no longer any question of who gets to be with him. This shows that they do not necessarily view a transactional marriage as problematic—even when Angustias would be the one offering up property. Poncia's attempt to help Bernarda see what is really going on demonstrates that, despite her deep hatred for Bernarda, she is still invested in the sisters' wellbeing (and the family's overall reputation). Unfortunately, Bernarda refuses to accept a reality that contradicts her fantasy: that her daughters will carry forth tradition and the bloodline by finding appropriate husbands in due time.



Poncia's comment reveals the true reason why Martirio's engagement collapsed: Bernarda sabotaged it because she thought Enrique was not high-class enough for her daughter. But Martirio does not know about her mother's involvement, and thus blames herself for Enrique's loss of interest. Thus, Bernarda is in some way responsible for Martirio's rabid jealousy, which unleashes the tragic conflict at the end of the play.



Poncia only wants to help: she has tried to inform Bernarda about the brewing conflict among her daughters because she hopes that, together, they can prevent it. But Bernarda continues to deny this reality instead of confronting it. For instance, she assumes that she will always be able to control her daughters by dominating them, even as they are growing more and more resistant to her control. This makes Bernarda's quote about things not fitting our fantasies all the more ironic. While Bernarda assumes that everyone will fall in line with the dictates of tradition, however, Poncia recognizes that the sisters no longer respect it—and particularly that Adela may be willing to ruin Angustias's marriage prospects to get Pepe for herself.



Poncia points out that her son saw Angustias and Pepe talking at four-thirty in the morning. Angustias enters to say that this is false, and Pepe leaves at one. Martirio comes in, too, and agrees that she heard Pepe leaving from the alley window at four o'clock. Angustias says she speaks to Pepe through her bedroom window, not the alley window. As Adela stands in the doorway, Bernarda, Poncia, and Martirio all realize that something is wrong. Adela accuses Poncia of trying to destroy the family; Bernarda agrees, calls the rumors false, and tells her daughters to ignore them. She insists that she will find out the truth for herself. Angustias says she wants to know what is happening, but Bernarda says that she has "no right except to obey."

The Maid announces that all the townspeople are gathering in the streets; Bernarda sends Poncia to figure out what is happening, but she chastises her daughters for breaking their mourning obligations when they try to follow. Everyone leaves but Martirio and Adela, who both threaten to expose the other. Martirio claims that she's attracted to Pepe, but hasn't done anything with him, and Adela claims that Pepe is trying to sleep with her, but she doesn't want to.

The other women return to the room, and Poncia explains what is happening outside. A neighbor's unmarried daughter just had a baby and killed it to hide her shame, but a pack of dogs found the body and dragged it to her doorstep. The townspeople have brought her out in the street and want to kill her. Bernarda announces that they should, as she has "trample[d] on decency." Adela says they should let the woman live, but Martirio stares straight at Adela and says, "Let her pay for what she did." Adela screams no and holds her womb. Bernarda yells "Kill her!" as the curtain falls.

ACT 3

Bernarda, her daughters, and a neighbor, Prudencia, are dining in the house's interior patio. Prudencia stands to leave, but Bernarda protests that they don't spend enough time together, and Prudencia agrees to stay because the last evening church bells haven't yet rung. Bernarda asks about Prudencia's husband. Prudencia explains that he enters the house by climbing a ladder into the corral, due to a dispute with his brothers over the inheritance, and he hasn't forgiven their daughter for her disobedience. Bernarda thinks he is right on both counts. But Prudencia is distraught and half-blind. Her only source of comfort is the church.

Poncia and Martirio's observations suggest that Pepe goes over to Adela's window after his evening chats with Angustias. This confirms Poncia's suspicion that Pepe and Adela are already carrying on an affair—a truth that Bernarda stubbornly refuses to accept. Her denial is closely linked to her faith in traditional women's honor codes: she fails to see Adela's adultery in part because she finds it unfathomable that one of her daughters could ever do something so dishonorable. As a corollary, since she thinks of marriage as inviolable (despite her own husband's adultery), she assumes that Angustias and Pepe's marriage will naturally end the conflict among her daughters. But she fails to realize that her daughters do not place the same credence in this honor code that she does.



This commotion pauses the play's action, which again shows how that gossip, honor, and reputation play a central role in Bernarda's village (and rural Spanish life more generally). This offers readers and audiences some insight into what it will mean for the townspeople to overhear any commotion in Bernarda's house going forward. Meanwhile, Martirio and Adela's rivalry keeps intensifying and suggests an impending tragic ending to the play.



In addition to showing how cruel and misogynistic Spain's traditional honor codes can be, Bernarda's reaction to the village woman's infidelity and infanticide suggests that she might respond to Adela's affair with Pepe in the same way—that is, if she ever realizes that it is happening. Of course, readers and audiences might also think that, given her great concern for her family's reputation, Bernarda would prefer to highlight such impropriety. Regardless, Bernarda's reaction clearly frightens Adela, who suggests that she may be pregnant by clutching her belly.



Prudencia's main role in the play is to reinforce the village's social norms and serve as a foil to Bernarda. They are both pious, conservative, and miserable precisely because of the norms that they impose on everyone else. And just as Prudencia is literally blind, Bernarda is blind to the dynamics in her family. Here, Bernarda's approval of Prudencia's husband's behavior—which is tearing her family apart—reflects the way she values reputation above all else, including her and her daughters' happiness.



There's a kick on the wall, and Bernarda explains that it's the **stallion** in the corral, who will be ready to breed in the morning. Poncia and Prudencia agree that Bernarda has an excellent herd. The stallion kicks again, and Bernarda orders Poncia to let him out and lock the mares inside.

Given the close association between men and horses in Spanish rural culture, as well as Amelia and Martirio's conversation about the mule in the corral in the middle of Act II, it's clear that this portion of the dinner conversation is an extended metaphor for gender dynamics, sex, and procreation. Namely, the stallion's desire to breed points to either Pepe and Angustias's coming marriage or Pepe's affair with Adela, and Bernarda's herd represents the pure, noble bloodline that she hopes to preserve by properly "breeding" (marrying) her daughters.



Adela gets up for water, but Bernarda orders her to sit down and calls for the Maid to bring water instead. Prudencia asks if Angustias will marry, and Bernarda joyously says that Pepe will propose to her in three days. Adela and Magdalena quarrel, and Angustias shows Prudencia her pearl ring. It's beautiful, but Prudencia comments that pearls used to represent tears—and Adela insists that they still do. Prudencia compliments Bernarda's furniture, and they agree that everything will work out alright. The church bells sound. Prudencia leaves, and the other women get up.

The end of the dinner scene continues to show how restrictive social codes pervade every aspect of life in Bernarda's village. Bernarda's insistence that the Maid bring the water reflects her desire to preserve class hierarchy, and Prudencia's comments about the ring indicate her subtle disapproval of Angustias's break from tradition. Of course, the association between pearls and tears also clearly foreshadows the tragedies to come. Prudencia's insistence on leaving when the church bells ring shows that she prefers to obey others rather than making decisions for herself.



Adela decides to go stand at the front door, and Amelia and Martirio insist on following her out. Meanwhile, as Angustias clears the table, Bernarda tells her to forgive Martirio for stealing the picture, which was a joke. Bernarda reminds Angustias that keeping up appearances is essential, and Angustias mentions that Pepe seemed worried and distracted during their conversation the previous night. Bernarda says women shouldn't ask about their husbands' worries, or even speak to them unless spoken to first. Angustias thinks Pepe is hiding things from her, but Bernarda tells her not to look for the truth, and especially not to cry in front of him. Angustias admits that she isn't happy about Pepe, and Bernarda says it doesn't matter.

Angustias's excitement has worn off because she has realized that her prospective marriage to Pepe is not what she once thought. As she is concerned primarily with her family's wealth, legacy, and reputation, Bernarda tries convincing Angustias to set aside her qualms about Pepe's intentions and misbehavior. Put differently, she wants Angustias to follow in her footsteps by forgetting her own happiness and blinding herself to the real power dynamics that surround her.



Adela, Amelia, and Martirio arrive. They comment on the **black** night, the giant white **stallion**, and the bright stars. Angustias goes to bed, since Pepe is in the city tonight and won't be visiting. Adela asks Bernarda why they pray to Santa Barbara when they see lighting and shooting stars, but Bernarda says that nobody remembers anymore. Adela likes to watch "things blazing though the sky, after being motionless year after year," but Amelia and Martirio prefer not to. Bernarda says that it's bedtime; the women wake up Magdalena, who has fallen asleep. She and Amelia go to bed; Bernarda explains that Pepe is out of town, and then Adela and Martirio go to bed too.

This exchange about the stars is an important metaphor for the sisters' desire for freedom and differing attitudes toward their predicament. Adela's question about Santa Barbara demonstrates the hollowness of tradition, which people seem to follow simply because they have lost the sense that things could be otherwise. And her quote about shooting stars points to her dream of freedom and independence, which she hopes will end her "motionless" life imprisoned in Bernarda's house and way of life. In contrast, like Bernarda, her sisters prefer not to dream of a freedom that they believe they will never achieve.



Poncia returns to the table, where Bernarda is sitting alone. Bernarda claims that she still hasn't seen the "monstrous thing" that Poncia was talking about, and that her daughters are perfectly happy. Poncia points out that nobody knows what the daughters really feel, but she promises to focus on taking care of the house and not cause any trouble. Bernarda asks if Poncia's son still hangs out with Pepe late at night and claims that there's no trouble left for them to get into because of her own "watchful eyes." Poncia says she doesn't want to say too much, but she warns that "Suddenly lightning may strike! Suddenly your heart may stop dead!" Bernarda says she's prepared for anything.

Whether the "monstrous thing" refers to Adela's apparent pregnancy, her affair with Pepe, or her conflict with Angustias and Martirio, Poncia's speech about focusing on housework shows that she has given up on trying to show Bernarda the truth or change her mind. Still, Poncia hopes that Bernarda will eventually come around: her warning about lightning or a heart attack is her way of asking what will happen to Bernarda's family without her. Bernarda clearly does not understand Poncia's point—in fact, she seems incapable of imagining her daughters as having their own relationships, separate from her influence. Meanwhile, Bernarda's attempt to take credit for Pepe staying out of trouble is deeply ironic, because of course he is getting into trouble with Adela right under her nose.



The Maid comes to report that she has finished the dishes, and Bernarda gets up to go to bed. Now alone, Poncia and the Maid agree that Bernarda prefers ignoring the truth to confronting it and underestimates Pepe's power over her daughters. Poncia blames Adela for leading Pepe on—and, rumor says, for letting him sleep with her. But now, Adela will "do whatever it takes" to have Pepe. And Martirio knows Pepe doesn't love her back, so she will "crush the world" if she can.

As servants, the Maid and Poncia are both privy to and removed from the family's drama. Thus, like in the play's opening scene, they clearly see Bernarda's errors, detail them for the audience's benefit, and foreshadow the coming conflict. Meanwhile, it's telling that Poncia blames Adela for her relationship with Pepe. Given how Poncia clashes with Bernarda, one might expect her to understand Adela's desire for freedom and love. Instead, she interprets the situation through the traditional misogynistic honor code, excusing Pepe (who seduced Adela despite planning to marry Angustias) and Bernarda (who led her daughters into this conflict by insisting that they can only marry a high-class man, when Pepe el Romano is the only one in town).



Adela walks by in her petticoats and bodice, gets a glass of water, and leaves. Poncia and the Maid leave for bed, but they worry that the barking dogs will keep them awake. Then, Maria Josefa walks onstage holding a baby ewe. She sings to it, calling it her child and telling it to follow her to the seashore. She sings that Bernarda and Magdalena are like a leopard and a hyena, then leaves. Adela sneaks across the stage and enters the corral; Martirio comes to the middle of the stage and waits anxiously, wearing a **black** shawl and petticoats.

Adela's behavior suggests that she is going to meet Pepe in the corral, and Martirio's indicates that she is aware of her sister's plans and intends to go spy on her. In her second surprise appearance, Maria Josefa again captures the play's central themes in an indirect way, showing how Spanish women have passed on a tradition of suffering and unfreedom from generation to generation. The white ewe, which she doubtless found in the corral, represents childhood, innocence, and the possibility of renewal or freedom.



Maria Josefa returns onstage, says she escaped her room, and asks if Martirio will let her outside. Martirio tells her to go to bed. Maria Josefa asks when Martirio will have a baby and claims the ewe as her own child. She rants about starting a new bloodline of **white-haired** children, while Bernarda's house is full of black veils for mourning. She remembers how she and the neighbor used to bring each other chocolate—but this no longer happens. She worries the dogs will attack her in the fields and asks Martirio to accompany her. Then, she warns that Pepe el Romano will “devour” the family's women. Maria Josefa sings again while Martirio returns her to her room and locks her inside.

Martirio sees Adela, whose hair is unkempt, and tells her to stay away from Pepe. But Adela says that Martirio is just jealous. Martirio declares that she has to speak out, and she warns Adela not to steal Pepe from Angustias. But Martirio admits she knows that Pepe really loves Adela, not Angustias—and that she is in love with him too. Adela announces that it's not her fault and tries to embrace Martirio, who pushes her away and says she no longer thinks of her as a sister.

Adela declares that Pepe is hers, even if this means “one of us has to drown.” Pepe has taken Adela down to the river to have sex with her, and Adela will do whatever it takes to be his, even if the whole town turns against her and even if it means ruining Angustias's marriage. Martirio vows to stop Adela, who says that “God must have abandoned me” because she no longer loves her sister. Adela tries to run out the door, but Martirio blocks her and calls out for Bernarda.

Bernarda comes onstage and Martirio notes the straw on Adela's petticoats. Bernarda calls Adela sinful, but Adela grabs Bernarda's cane and snaps it in half. She likens Bernarda's house to a prison and the cane to a “tyrant's rod;” she says that only Pepe can tell her what to do anymore, because she is his. Angustias enters; Adela tells her to go out to the corral, where Pepe is waiting, and tell him the truth. “The gun!” exclaims Bernarda, who runs offstage with Martirio. Angustias grabs Adela to stop her from leaving.

Maria Josefa and Martirio meet onstage because, to some extent, they are foils for each other: both articulate a desire for freedom through love, marriage, and family—the key components of traditional Spanish womanhood, but without the unfreedom that it entails in Bernarda's village and family. She highlights this difference by returning to the play's ongoing contrast between white (birth, innocence, purity, and virginity) and black (death, mourning, and widowhood). Her warning about Pepe foreshadows the play's ending, and her comment about chocolate points to the way traditions are changing in 20th-century Spain—and the social foundation of village life is starting to fray as a result.



Adela and Martirio's feud comes to a head: Martirio cannot bear to watch her sister get the love and freedom that she has been denied. Even though Martirio presents her objection as a defense of Angustias, it's clear that her real motivation is jealousy. Her rejection of Adela as a sister demonstrates that their conflict has finally and fatally torn their family apart.



Adela and Martirio both agree that they are willing to undermine the family in order to get what they want. Martirio's comment about God reflects how the family's attempt to fulfill tradition has actually led them to undermine it instead. Not only are the sisters unable to find husbands, but Martirio—whose name means martyrdom—has lost her faith.



Bernarda appears to finally recognize Adela's sin, but she will soon forget about it, which raises the question of whether she is lying or simply unwilling to accept what's happening. Adela's great act of rebellion—breaking the cane her mother uses to beat her and her sisters—demonstrates that she will prioritize her freedom and pursuit of love even if it goes against tradition. And when Bernarda goes after Pepe, she risks again rashly undermining a marriage prospect for her daughters—although given Pepe's behavior, she may be justified this time.



Bernarda and Martirio return to the stage, and Martirio triumphantly declares that Pepe is no more. Distraught, Adela runs off into her room. Then, Martirio admits that they didn't actually hit Pepe—they shot at him, and he rode his **horse** away into the night—but she wanted to punish Adela by making her think Pepe was dead. Bernarda and Poncia try to make Adela open the door, and the Maid reports that the neighbors have woken up.

Poncia shoves open Adela's door, runs inside, screams, and then runs back to the stage, clutching her own throat. Bernarda warns that Pepe will suffer for this and announces that "my daughter has died a virgin." But Martirio says that Adela "was fortunate a thousand times over—she had him." Bernarda tells her remaining daughters to "look death in the face" instead of crying. She yells "Silence!" and the curtain falls.

Martirio's cruel lie shows that she remains bitterly jealous at her sister Adela and suggests that she followed Bernarda into the corral partially in the hopes of getting back at Pepe (who rejected her advances in favor of Adela). The Maid's comment about the neighbors evokes Bernarda's greatest fear: ruining her family's reputation by causing a scandal in front of the whole village.



Poncia's throat-clutching indicates that Adela has committed suicide by hanging herself. Bernarda's reaction is ironic, because it's precisely Adela's refusal to choose between virginity and marriage that has indirectly led to her death. Bernarda may just call Adela a virgin because she thinks the neighbors are listening in, but more likely, she still fails to see the truth that Adela was pregnant with Pepe's child. Martirio's comment that Adela was lucky to have Pepe suggests that, rather than blaming herself for her sister's death, she continues to blame her sister for having the freedom and romance that she cannot. Bernarda's comment about death is García Lorca's plea to the audience: by recognizing the inevitability of death, he thinks, they can learn to make the most of their lives. And Bernarda closes the play in exactly the same way as she entered it in Act I: by screaming "Silence!" This line could be interpreted as García Lorca further evoking death for the audience, or in retrospect as a haunting prediction of the coming Spanish Civil War and Franco dictatorship.





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